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CITY: PG 3
Rescuing lives, restoring dignity

NATION: PG 5
Stage set for Himanta to take oath as Assam CM for 2nd term

FILM: PG 12
It was a big lull: Kiara Advani

PM REPEATS CALL FOR SAVING FUEL, CUTTING GOLD BUY

India has sufficient fuel stocks, no rationing planned, says govt amid Rs 1,000 cr/day loss

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India will not resort to fuel rationing despite prolonged global supply disruptions, the government said on Monday, even as state-run oil companies face daily losses of up to Rs 1,200 crore and Prime Minister Narendra Modi called on citizens to conserve fuel, cut imports and curb foreign exchange outflows.

At the Confederation of Indian Industry Annual Business Summit, Oil Secretary Neeraj Mittal sought to reassure markets and consumers, stating that fuel supplies remain stable and sufficient. "There is no need to panic. There are sufficient supplies. There is no rationing in place. It's not going to happen," he said, underlining that India has maintained around 60 days of fuel stocks and roughly 45 days of LPG inventories through nearly 10 weeks of global disruption.

The assurance comes against the backdrop of heightened geopolitical tensions in West Asia that have strained global energy flows and pushed up crude prices. Despite these pressures, petrol and diesel prices in India have remained unchanged for nearly two years. The decision to hold retail prices steady, even as input costs have surged by more than 50 per cent, has resulted in significant financial strain on public sector oil marketing companies, with estimated losses ranging between Rs 1,000 crore and Rs 1,200 crore per day.

Officials indicated that maintaining price and supply stability remains the government's default approach, even as it navigates the financial impact. Fiscal measures, including excise duty cuts on petrol and diesel, have been deployed to cushion consumers, with revenue implications estimated at around Rs 1.6 lakh crore.

Mittal said India has managed the crisis by diversifying crude sourcing, securing additional cargoes and increasing procurement from existing suppliers. He added that the country's large refining capacity has helped absorb shocks, ensuring domestic demand is met while exports of refined petroleum products continue.

"The constraint has not changed at all. In fact, it is a shade worse," Mittal said, referring to ongoing disruptions in global shipments. He noted that India successfully navigated logistical challenges, including moving 14 ships through the conflict-affected Strait of Hormuz during the period.

Alongside supply-side measures, the government has also implemented calibrated demand management. LPG distribution has been prioritised for household cooking needs, while industrial supply has been restored to about 70 per cent following requests from industry. Nearly full digital tracking of LPG deliveries has also helped curb diversion and black-market activity.

India, the world's third-largest oil consumer, uses about 5 million barrels of crude per day. While strategic petroleum reserves are part Continued on P4

CLOSER LOOK

- » Oil Secretary Neeraj Mittal said the country has about 60 days of fuel stocks and 45 days of LPG inventory
- » Government maintained stable retail fuel prices for nearly two years despite over 50% rise in input costs
- » State-run oil companies are incurring losses of Rs 1,000 crore to Rs 1,200 crore per day
- » Excise duty cuts helped absorb price shocks, with an estimated revenue impact of Rs 1.6 lakh crore
- » India secured additional crude cargoes and diversified sourcing to manage supply disruptions
- » 14 Indian ships navigated through the conflict-hit Strait of Hormuz during the crisis period
- » LPG supply prioritised for households, with industrial supply restored to about 70%

'LAND TRANSFER PROCESS BEGINS TODAY ITSELF...'

Bengal clears land transfer to BSF for int'l border fencing

Suvendu Adhikari with other Bengal Cabinet minister, in Kolkata, on Monday PIC/GAUTAM BOSE

'Census will begin in Bengal through special administrative order'

SOUMITRA NANDI

KOLKATA: In a major policy decision taken immediately after assuming office, the newly formed BJP government in Bengal on Monday approved the transfer of land to the Border Security Force (BSF) for fencing along sensitive international border areas.

Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari also confirmed that Bengal has now activated the Union government's directive and that the Census process in Bengal would begin immediately through a special administrative order.

The land decision was cleared during the first Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari, who directed officials to complete the entire land transfer process within 45 days. West Bengal shares a long and strategically sensitive international border.

According to official data, the state has nearly 2,216.7 km of border with Bangladesh, of which around 1,647.696 km has already been fenced. However, nearly 569.004 km still remains unfenced. Apart from Bangladesh, the state also shares international borders with Bhutan and Nepal.

Concerns over illegal infiltration through unfenced stretches have remained a major political and administrative issue in the state for years.

Addressing the media after the Cabinet meeting, Adhikari stressed the importance of strengthening border security and raised Continued on P4

FIRST CABINET MEET

- » The land decision was cleared during the first Cabinet meeting chaired by Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari, who directed officials to complete the entire land transfer process within 45 days
- » Bengal has nearly 2,216.7 km of border with Bangladesh, of which around 1,647.696 km has already been fenced
- » However, nearly 569.004 km still remains unfenced. Apart from Bangladesh, the state also shares international borders with Bhutan and Nepal
- » 'Whatever land the BSF requires will be provided. The Land Department has already completed much of the groundwork'
- » 'Bengal would now officially function under the new criminal law (BNS, BNSS & BSA) regime from Monday, with all police and legal procedures shifting to the updated framework'

India taking concrete measures to shield supply chains amid West Asia crisis

Rajnath Singh

In today's paper ...

SOMNATH AMRUT MAHOTSAV

'No power can make India bow or yield to pressure'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

SOMNATH (GUJARAT): Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Monday invoked the memory of India's 1998 nuclear tests to underline what he described as the country's resolve to withstand global pressure, saying no force in the world can make India bow. He was speaking at the Somnath Amrut Mahotsav, marking 75 years since the inauguration of the restored Somnath Temple.

Addressing the gathering, Modi linked May 11 with two defining moments in India's history: the consecration of the temple in 1951 and the nuclear tests conducted in 1998 under then Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee. "On May 11, 1998, the nation conducted its nuclear tests. Our scientists demonstrated India's capabilities and potential to the entire world," he said, recalling how the tests "sent shockwaves across the globe".

> GLOBAL POWERS MOBILISED TO SUPPRESS INDIA. VARIOUS SANCTIONS WERE IMPOSED, AND EVERY PASSAGE TO AVERT A POTENTIAL ECONOMIC CRISIS WAS BLOCKED

The Prime Minister described the international reaction that followed, noting that several countries responded with anger and imposed sanctions aimed at isolating India. "Global powers mobilised to suppress India. Various sanctions were imposed, and every passage to avert a potential economic crisis was blocked," he said. Continued on P4

Cracks in AIADMK: 30 MLAs back rebel camp, pressure mounts on EPS

MPOST BUREAU

CHENNAI: The AIADMK is witnessing a sharp internal rift following a poor performance in the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections as the party contested 167 seats and could win only 47 out of 234 seats.

The party is sharply divided over whether to support the new ruling party, Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK), with several MLAs, led by senior members like S P Velumani and CV Shanmugam, demanding the resignation of General Secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami (EPS).

The party is facing a potential vertical split, with MLAS divided into two groups, one led by EPS and another group led by leaders like S P Velumani.

> A faction of MLAs is open to supporting or joining a coalition with Vijay's TVK government, while others remain opposed

Several MLAs and leaders want EPS to step down following the electoral defeat, blaming him for taking unilateral decisions. A faction of MLAs is open to supporting or joining a coalition with Vijay's TVK government, while others remain opposed.

AIADMK stands divided over support to TVK, some MLAs want EPS to step down. Continued on P4

TMC TELLS SC

'BJP's victory margin less than SIR voter deletions in 31 seats'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA: The Trinamool Congress (TMC) on Monday told the Supreme Court that deletions carried out during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls had materially affected the outcome in several Assembly constituencies in West Bengal, claiming that in many seats the number of deleted voters was higher than the BJP's margin of victory.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi asked the TMC to file a separate interlocutory application containing detailed constituency-wise figures on the alleged impact of the deletions. Justice Bagchi observed that the issue would require independent consideration by the court.

In an earlier SIR case hearing, Justice Bagchi had remarked that Continued on P4

THE CASE

- » The court asked the TMC to file a separate interlocutory application containing detailed constituency-wise figures
- » In one Constituency, Kalyan Bandhopadhyay said, the margin of defeat was 862 votes while more than 5432 persons had been removed from the electoral rolls for adjudication
- » 'Suppose margin is 2% and 15% of the electorate who are mapped could not vote, then maybe, we are not expressing any opinion, but we would definitely have to apply our minds'

No plan to evacuate Indians from Fujairah or from UAE: MEA

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of External Affairs on Monday rejected a report which claimed that India and the UAE were 'working on an agreement' to facilitate the evacuation of Indian workers through Fujairah port, saying there is "no basis" for it, and that there is "no plan to evacuate" Indian nationals from Fujairah or from the UAE.

External Affairs Ministry's spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said this in response to a query about a media report published in a leading national daily, during an inter-ministerial briefing here on the current situation in West Asia.

"You talked about a particular news item. I would also request you to look at MEA FactCheck because we've already issued a clarification on this account. There is no basis, in fact, for such a story. Also, there is no plan to evacuate Indian nationals from Fujairah or from the UAE. So, also please do look at the clarification that we've issued," he said.

Earlier in the day, the MEA's fact-check team posted on its X account, labelling the report as "fake news."

"Fake News Alert! There is no basis in fact for such a story. There is no evacuation being planned. Please stay alert against such false and baseless claims," MEA Continued on P4

EC set to roll out phase III of SIR in 'coming days'; to cover 22 states, UTs

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Election Commission of India is preparing to launch the third phase of its Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the coming days, officials said on Monday. The exercise is expected to cover the remaining 22 states and Union Territories, accounting for nearly 40 crore electors.

The rollout had been deferred due to assembly elections held last month in Kerala, Assam, Puducherry, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal. With the poll process now complete, officials indicated that preparations for the next phase are in place and implementation could begin shortly.

So far, the SIR exercise has been conducted across 10 states and three Union Territories, including Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh, Kerala, Puducherry, the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Lakshadweep, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, Goa and Bihar. A separate special revision was also undertaken in Assam. Continued on P4

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Around 60 crore of India's nearly 99 crore voters already covered in earlier phases
- » Phase III will complete nationwide revision across all states and UTs

MGNREGA TO BE REPEALED

Centre sets July 1 for roll-out of VB-G RAM G Act

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Union government on Monday announced that the Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025 will be implemented nationwide from July 1, formally replacing the two-decade-old Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act. While the scheme had been unveiled earlier, the latest notification confirms the date from which the new rural employment framework will take effect, marking a significant transition in how wage employment programmes will operate across rural areas.

According to the Ministry of Rural Development, the shift is being positioned as part of the broader "Viksit Bharat @2047" vision, with the government describing it as a "historic transition" in rural development architecture. The new law expands the statutory guarantee of wage employment from 100 days under the previous system to 125 days per rural household annually, while also seeking to integrate employment generation with infrastructure creation, climate resilience and decentralised planning. Official notifications state that the new Act will come into force across all states and Union Territories on July 1, and the existing law will stand repealed from the same date. Continued on P4

TAKEAWAYS

- » 125 days of rural wage work (up from 100)
- » Ongoing works continue seamlessly
- » Old job cards temporarily valid
- » No work denial due to pending e-KYC
- » Job within 15 days of demand or unemployment allowance
- » Wages via DBT, paid weekly/within 15 days
- » Delay compensation retained
- » Face-authentication attendance (with exceptions)
- » Work may be restricted during peak farm seasons
- » Budget: Rs 95,692.31 crore (2026–27 BE)
- » Total outlay with states to be Rs 1.51 lakh crore

NEHRU PLACE: 4 IDENTIFIED, 2 DETAINED

Two women from Assam, Bihar assaulted, molested

OUR CORRESPONDENT

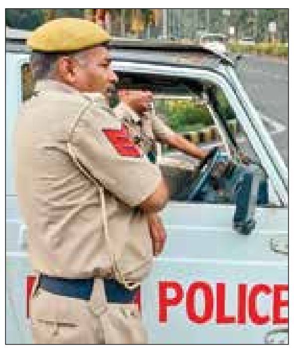
NEW DELHI: Two women, one from Assam and the other from Bihar, were allegedly molested, assaulted, and subjected to racist remarks by a group of men outside a hotel in southeast Delhi's Nehru Place, with police identifying four suspects and detaining two of them.

"Out of the two women, one is from Assam, and the other is from Bihar. Two out of the four identified accused have been detained, and interrogation is going on," a senior police officer said, assuring that others will be apprehended soon.

The incident occurred around 6.30 am on May 10, near a tea stall outside the hotel. A call regarding women in distress was received by the Kalkaji Police Station at around 7 am, prompting local police teams to rush to the scene, where they found the two women.

"Preliminary enquiry revealed that the women were allegedly subjected to derogatory remarks and abuses by a group of men, which later escalated into a physical altercation," a senior police officer said. According to the women, they were having tea outside the hotel when two men started catcalling them. Soon, several others allegedly joined in, leading to an argument that later turned violent.

"One of the complainants alleged that she was molested during the incident and that her clothes were torn. The women also alleged that racist remarks were passed against them by the accused," the officer said. Additionally, one of



KEY POINTS

» According to the women, they were having tea outside the hotel when two men started catcalling them

» Soon, several others allegedly joined in, leading to an argument that later turned violent

the women claimed she was attacked with a bamboo stick while they were trying to leave the area. The accused allegedly blocked their path and threatened them with consequences if they reported the incident.

"Both women were rushed to AIIMS for medical examination after police reached the scene. A case has been registered at the Kalkaji police station under Sections 115 (2) (voluntarily causing hurt), 74 (assault of criminal force to against a woman with the intent to outrage her modesty), 126(2) (wrongful restraint), 351(2) (criminal intimidation), 78 (stalking) and 3(5) (common intentions) of the BNS on May 10 and investigation was taken up immediately," the officer said.

According to the FIR, the women told the police that they were having tea when two men first started catcalling them. "Then, their friends joined in and started poking us. The accused beat my friend and even tore her clothes. They used obscene language towards us," read the FIR.

The women informed the police that they would be able to identify the accused if they were presented before them.

As part of the probe, CCTV footage from nearby areas was scanned, and several witnesses and passersby present during the incident were identified and questioned. During the investigation, eight individuals, including witnesses and passersby, were rounded up and questioned, following which four main accused involved in the incident were identified, police said. Multiple police teams were formed, and raids were conducted at locations linked to the accused to apprehend the rest of the accused.

Several videos of the incident surfaced on social media, providing crucial leads to investigators.

"It appears the women recorded some of the videos during the altercation, clearly capturing the faces of several accused, which quickly aided the police in their identification process," a police officer privy to the investigation said.

According to police, one of the clips, around two minutes long, purportedly shows a group of men hurling abuses at the women while appearing to be under the influence of alcohol.

Driver apprehended for siphoning Rs 2.57L from Alzheimer's patient via UPI transactions in Delhi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 39-year-old driver, who had worked with a family for nearly 15 years, was arrested for allegedly exploiting an elderly Alzheimer's patient and siphoning off Rs 2.57 lakh through unauthorised UPI transactions in central Delhi, police said on Monday.

The accused, identified as Devinder, allegedly took advantage of the victim's severe memory loss and secretly accessed his mobile phone multiple times to transfer money into accounts linked to his associates, they said.

According to police, the fraudulent transactions were

carried out between April 4 and April 15 from the bank account of the elderly man, who was suffering from Alzheimer's disease and severe short-term memory impairment.

"The matter came to light after the victim's son lodged a

> He exploited the victim's deteriorating cognitive condition, believing that the elderly man would not remember the transactions

complaint through the NCRP helpline, reporting suspicious UPI transactions amounting to Rs 2.57 lakh from his father's account," a senior police officer said.

Initially, the family suspected that an unknown cyber fraudster was involved. However, during investigation, it emerged that the accused was someone known and trusted by the family, said the officer.

Police said Devinder had been employed as a driver and domestic help at the complainant's residence for around 15 years and was fully aware of the victim's medical condition.

He exploited the victim's deteriorating cognitive condition, believing that the elderly man would not remember the transactions.

A case was registered and analysed the digital transaction trail, bank account details and beneficiary records connected with the fraudulent UPI transfers. During the probe, the financial trail led police to Devinder, a resident of Mandoli in northeast Delhi.

Police said the accused abruptly left his job on May 5 and went into hiding after siphoning the money in an attempt to evade arrest.

"Following sustained technical surveillance and local intelligence gathering, he was apprehended from GTB Nagar on May 8," the officer added.

During interrogation, Devinder allegedly confessed to the crime and admitted that he had gained the family's trust over the years while working at their house. Police said further investigation is underway.

Software engineer quits high-paying job, runs Rs 99 cr fake trading app scam; held

NEW DELHI: A 31-year-old software engineer who was earning nearly Rs 30 lakh annually at a multinational company allegedly abandoned his corporate career to run a fake online trading racket that duped hundreds of investors across the country of nearly Rs 100 crore, the Delhi Police said on Monday. The accused, identified as Ravi Rathore, was arrested from Bengaluru along with two associates following a multi-state operation, it said.

According to investigators, the syndicate used a fake mobile application and a fraudulent website to lure victims into investing money in the name of trading with promises of huge guaranteed returns.

"The fraud came to light after a resident of Paharganj lodged a complaint on the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal, alleging that he had been cheated through a fake online trading platform," Deputy Commissioner of Police (Central) Rohit Rajveer Singh said in a statement. The complainant allegedly received calls and messages from unknown people who persuaded him to download the mobile application, the officer said.

> 'Fraudsters claimed their company used advanced software-based techniques in stock mkt, assured him that investments would bring heavy profits without any financial risk'

The fraudsters claimed their company used advanced software-based techniques in the stock market and assured him that the investments would generate heavy profits without any financial risk.

Believing their claims, the complainant transferred Rs 10,000 in multiple transactions through different online payment systems, the officer said.

Initially, the application displayed fake profits on a daily basis to gain the victim's confidence and encourage him to invest more money. "However, whenever he attempted to withdraw the amount, he was allegedly asked to deposit additional funds on various pretexts such as taxes, account activation, and processing charges," the DCP said. Police said the complainant became suspicious after coming across government advisories regarding cyber fraud and immediately reported the matter, following which an FIR was registered on May 1.

During the investigation, police carried out extensive technical analysis, digital surveillance, financial transaction examination, IP tracking, and server log analysis.

Police said the accused ran an interstate cyber fraud syndicate targeting online investors through a fake trading application. Investigation revealed 636 victim accounts and over 14,200 transactions involving nearly Rs 99.77 crore. The accused allegedly used the proceeds to buy properties, luxury vehicles and fund local cricket tournaments. PTI

SARITA VIHAR

BSES opens high performance basketball centre

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: BSES has inaugurated a High Performance Basketball Centre at Sarita Vihar in partnership with the Dribble Academy Foundation as part of its corporate social responsibility initiative.

The facility is the fifth centre under the BSES Basketball Academy network, which focuses on identifying and training young basketball players in Delhi. More than 1,100 students are currently enrolled across four feeder centres located in I.P. Extension, West Vinod Nagar and Fatehpur Beri.

According to officials, the new centre will provide advanced coaching and training facilities for selected players. The programme will include skill development sessions, strength and conditioning training, nutrition support, recovery programmes, mentorship and video-based performance analysis.

BSES Director V. S. Verma, senior company officials and representatives of the Dribble Academy Foundation were present at the inauguration ceremony.

Students from the feeder centres also participated in basketball demonstrations during the event.

Dog beaten to death, activist accused of assaulting guard

NEW DELHI: A stray dog death case in west Delhi's Kirti Nagar has sparked controversy after a security guard was accused of fatally assaulting the animal with an iron rod, while an animal rights activist was separately accused of assaulting the guard outside the local police station.

Police said a complaint was lodged on May 8 by a Ramesh Nagar resident alleging that guard Vinod Paswan attacked the dog in Kirti Nagar's J Block on May 7, causing injuries that later proved fatal.

During enquiry, police also learnt that animal activist Jasmeet Kaur allegedly assaulted the guard outside Kirti Nagar Police Station.

No formal complaint has been filed in that matter so far. Further investigation is underway. MPOST

One shooter of Deepak Nandal gang killed in encounter; another injured

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: An alleged shooter of gangster Deepak Nandal's gang was killed while another was injured in an encounter with Gurugram police on Monday, officials said.

Both the shooters were arrested from Punjab on Saturday in connection with firing at the house of singer Rahul Fazilpuria's event organiser, Saurabh Yadav, in Kanhai Village in Sector 45, they added.

According to the police, the shooter killed during the crossfire was identified as Gursher Singh alias Shera (23), and the other as Jaspal alias Bablu (28), both residents of Tarn Taran in Punjab.

Jaspal has been shifted to the hospital. A constable, Naveen, was also injured in the operation and was shifted for treatment.

According to the police, the encounter occurred near Bandhwari village at around 9.30 am

> The accused launched a deadly attack, firing 8-10 bullets at the police team with the intent to kill them

when the police team had taken both the accused to recover weapons. During the recovery, the accused picked up three pistols hidden near Bandhwadi and started firing indiscriminately at the police.

"The accused launched a deadly attack, firing 8-10 bullets at the police team with the intent to kill them. In retaliation, the police fired four rounds, and Gursher died on the spot, while Jaspal was injured," the police said.

The police said that the accused on last Saturday night opened fire at Yadav's house.

In this attack, Constable Kulbir, deployed for Yadav's security, was injured after being hit by two bullets. The accused then fled the scene.

An FIR was registered at the Sector 40 police station.

While investigating, the police had arrested four accused from Gurugram on May 4 and 5. They were identified as Ashok alias Pahalwan (35) and Manoj Kabar (46), residents of Rohtak, and Sumit (33) and Vicky (36), residents of Sonipat in Haryana. They were all accomplices of the shooters.

"During police interrogation, the accused revealed that they had come to kill Saurabh Yadav. The house of Saurabh was shown by the other arrested accused, and vehicles, weapons and other assistance were provided to carry out the crime," the police said.

Six accused have been arrested so far in this case. Gursher and Jaspal were the main shooters. A further probe is underway, he added.

Rajasthan man duped by fake policemen, three apprehended

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police have busted a gang of fake police officers accused of duping a Rajasthan-based man by impersonating law enforcement personnel in northwest Delhi. The accused were identified as Vinay alias Monty (20) and Kuldeep (30), both residents of Sonipat in Haryana. Three accused, including a juvenile, were apprehended from Haryana, police said.

According to police, cash worth Rs 33.5 lakh, two expensive mobile phones allegedly purchased using the cheated money, the bag used in the crime, and the motorcycle used during the offence were recovered from the accused.

The matter came to light after a complaint was lodged at Mangolpuri Police Station on May 9.

The complainant, Savaram, a resident of Rajasthan's Sirohi district, told police that he and his friend had arrived in Pitampura carrying cash on behalf of his employer. As they got down from an autorickshaw near the Vardhman Plaza bus stand and walked towards Tarun Enclave, two men intercepted them while posing as police personnel.

The accused allegedly questioned the complainant, seized the bag containing cash, and asked him to wait, claiming that senior officers were on their way.

The duo then fled the spot on a Splendor motorcycle.

Initially, the complainant told police that the bag contained Rs 9 lakh. However, during sustained questioning, he disclosed that the actual amount was Rs 50 lakh, stating that fear had prevented him from revealing the full amount earlier.

Following the complaint, police registered an FIR under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and launched an investigation.

Using CCTV footage, technical surveillance and informer inputs, police apprehended Vinay, Kuldeep and a juvenile from Haryana's Gohana on May 10. Efforts are underway to arrest the remaining accused and recover the remaining cheated amount.

News at a Glance

MAN STRANGLES 6-YR-OLD SON DEAD, DIES BY SUICIDE IN GGM

GURUGRAM: A 32-year-old man allegedly strangled his six-year-old son to death before dying by suicide at his house in Dayalpur village. The accused, identified as Sagar, was reportedly addicted to gambling and alcohol. Police said his wife had been living separately with their son and her family in neighbouring Machhagar village due to his behaviour. On Sunday, Sagar brought the child back to Dayalpur and allegedly killed him before hanging himself from a ceiling fan. The incident came to light after a neighbour alerted police. Preliminary investigation suggests financial distress and loneliness may have driven the act.

MAN JUMPS FROM METRO STN, DIES

NOIDA: A 45-year-old man allegedly died by suicide after jumping from the Electronic City Metro Station in Noida's Sector 63 area on Monday morning, police said. Police rushed to the spot after receiving information about the incident and shifted the injured man to a hospital, where he was declared dead. Officials said the body has been sent for post-mortem and efforts are underway to establish the identity of the deceased. According to police, preliminary examination of CCTV footage suggested that the man appeared to be mentally unstable. Further proceedings are underway.

10 FIREARMS, 81 CARTRIDGES SEIZED

Six linked to Rashid Cable Wala & Hashim Baba gangs arrested

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Crime Branch has arrested six alleged sharpshooters and operatives linked to the notorious Rashid Cable Wala and Hashim Baba gangs under "Operation Gang Bust 2.0".

The accused were identified as Faiz Qureshi, Maaz, Nawajish, Affak, Imran alias Teli and Arshad alias Chota, all residents of northeast Delhi.

Police recovered 10 illegal firearms, including nine sophisticated pistols and a .312 bore rifle, along with 81 live cartridges. A Maruti Baleno car allegedly used by the gang members was also seized.

The operation was carried out by a Crime Branch team led by Inspector Prakash Chand under the supervision of ACP Raj Kumar and DCP Harsh Indora.

Acting on specific intelligence received on May 6, police learnt that operatives linked

> Interrogation and follow-up raids led to the arrest of two more gang members: Police

to fugitive gangster Rashid Cable Wala and jailed gangster Hashim Baba had assembled at a lounge in Karol Bagh. Owing to the heavy public presence inside the establishment, police maintained surveillance outside and apprehended four suspects at around 4.05 am as they exited the premises.

According to police, four illegal pistols, including two Italy-made Beretta pistols, and 32 live cartridges were recovered from their vehicle.

Further interrogation and follow-up raids led to the arrest of two more gang members and additional recoveries of weapons and incriminating material.

Investigators said the accused were allegedly in direct contact with Rashid Cable Wala through the encrypted Signal application and were involved in betting, extortion and armed criminal activities.

Police said Rashid, wanted in multiple murder and extortion cases, is believed to be operating from Dubai, while Hashim Baba is currently lodged in Tihar Jail. Efforts are underway to identify illegal arms suppliers and dismantle the wider gang network operating in Delhi.

Three minors stab 18-yr-old over enmity

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: An 18-year-old boy was allegedly stabbed by three juveniles in outer Delhi's Sultanpuri area following a dispute over minor issues, police said on Monday. They said police received a PCR call on Sunday informing that a youth has been taken to hospital with a stab injury on his left thigh.

The injured, identified as Naitik, was admitted to Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital for treatment.

During inquiry, Naitik told police that three boys -- aged 15 to 16 years -- with whom he had previous enmity over minor issues, attacked him with a knife, a senior police officer said. Based on the victim's statement, a case has been registered at Sultanpuri police station, he said. "One of the accused, a juvenile, has been apprehended. Efforts are underway to trace the remaining two involved in the attack," the officer said.

Shahdara: 2 caught in labourer murder case

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police have arrested two men for the alleged murder of a 35-year-old labourer whose decomposed body was found buried under sand at an under-construction building in northeast Delhi's Shahdara area.

The accused were identified as Aakash Rai (25) and Man Singh Rai alias Ranu (25), both residents of Tikamgarh in Madhya Pradesh.

Police said the body was discovered on May 6 after a foul smell was reported from the fourth floor of an under-construction building in Naveen Shahdara.

A police team reached the spot and found the body concealed beneath a pile of sand. Due to the advanced stage of decomposition, identification was initially difficult.

During investigation, police examined footage from nearly 100 CCTV cameras and carried out extensive local inquiries.

Suspicion fell on the two

accused, who worked as chowkidars at a nearby construction site and were last seen with the deceased on the night of May 2.

Police said the duo abruptly left Delhi on May 4 and switched off their mobile phones. Teams were sent to Tikamgarh, where both were arrested after multiple raids.

During interrogation, the accused allegedly confessed to killing Ram Sewak, Aakash's brother-in-law, following a drunken quarrel over a trivial issue. Police said the body was later buried under sand to conceal the crime.

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Rescuing lives, restoring dignity

SERVING HUMANITY: CM Rekha Gupta flags off 'Seva & Rescue Campaign'

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major humanitarian outreach, the Delhi government on Monday launched a citywide 'Seva & Rescue Campaign' aimed at rescuing homeless, sick and destitute people living in vulnerable conditions across the national capital. Chief Minister Rekha Gupta flagged off the five-day campaign from Mukhyamantri Seva Sadan with a fleet of specially equipped ambulances and rescue vehicles, calling the initiative a mission to restore dignity, treatment and shelter to the abandoned and helpless.

The intensive drive, which will continue till May 15, is being jointly conducted by the Delhi government's Department of Social Welfare, Apna Ghar Ashram and Seva Bharti across all 13 districts of Delhi. Around 300 vulnerable people are expected to benefit from the campaign in its first phase.

A total of 19 rescue ambulances, 10 support vehicles, nearly 100 staff members and 50 volunteers have been deployed for the operation. Rescue teams will identify homeless, abandoned, sick and differently-abled people living on roadsides, railway stations, bus stands, religious places and other public spaces and shift them to shelter homes for treatment and rehabilitation.

Addressing the gathering, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said, "Serving humanity is the top priority of our government. No one in need should be deprived of help." She added that the rescue teams would ensure that those abandoned on the streets receive immediate care, treatment and safe shelter facilities.

> Serving humanity is the top priority of our govt. No one in need should be deprived of help
>
> — CM Rekha Gupta

The Chief Minister said rescued persons would be shifted to Apna Ghar Ashram, where arrangements have been made for medical treatment, food, care and rehabilitation. "If the families of rescued individuals are identified and willing to take them back, efforts will be made to reunite them with their loved ones after recovery," she said, adding that those without family support would continue receiving compassionate care at the Ashram.

Praising the contribution of Apna Ghar Ashram, the Chief Minister said the organisation had been "serving humanity in the truest sense" by providing respectful care to thousands of elderly and destitute citizens. She noted that many people suffering from serious illnesses and neglect are forced to live on the streets without access to treatment or shelter.

Under the campaign, priority will be given to patients suffering from serious illnesses such as tuberculosis, cancer and AIDS. The government has arranged accommodation for up to 500 destitute persons, including 100 beds for women and 400 for men.

To streamline rescue operations, the government has also established a dedicated 24x7 one-window system in coordination with the Social Welfare Department. Officials said nearly 20 people have already been rescued successfully in the first phase of the campaign.

Min Sood directs regular fire audits

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is preparing a comprehensive long-term Fire Fighting Master Plan to strengthen fire safety infrastructure and improve emergency response mechanisms across the Capital, Delhi Home Minister Ashish Sood said on Monday while chairing a high-level review meeting of the Delhi Fire Services at the Delhi Secretariat.

> A long-term Fire Fighting Master Plan will be prepared keeping in mind Delhi's growing population and urbanisation

The meeting was attended by senior fire department officials and divisional officers from all six divisions of Delhi. Discussions focused on fire prevention measures, modernization of firefighting systems, procurement of advanced equipment and improving emergency preparedness in view of Delhi's growing population and rapid urbanisation.

Addressing officials, Ashish Sood said, "A long-term Fire Fighting Master Plan will be prepared keeping in mind Delhi's growing population and urbanisation." He added that the government is committed to modernising the fire department to make the capital safer from fire incidents.

During the meeting, the Home Minister reviewed issues related to response time, availability of modern fire vehicles, internal communication systems and the proposed command and control infrastructure. He directed officials to strengthen and technologically upgrade the fire safety system to ensure swift and effective action during emergencies.

"Delhi's fire department will be further modernized to make the city safer from fire incidents," Sood said. He stressed that divisional officers must take direct responsibility for fire prevention and control in their respective areas.

The minister also instructed officials to conduct awareness campaigns in coordination with RWAs, market associations and social organisations. These campaigns will include mock drills, awareness sessions on "Do's and Don'ts" during fire incidents and preventive safety measures.

Sood further directed the Fire Department to conduct regular fire audits of schools, colleges, hospitals and night shelters. He also called for an inter-departmental coordination meeting involving Delhi Police, DDA, MCD, DISCOMs and other civic agencies to strengthen disaster preparedness and fire safety management across the Capital.

Govt plans higher funding for upkeep of parks & gardens

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is considering increased financial assistance for maintenance and development of parks and gardens across the city, including a proposal for full government funding for eligible projects undertaken by RWAs, NGOs and registered societies.

According to an official statement issued by the Chief Minister's Office on Monday, the proposed revisions aim to strengthen and expand Delhi's green cover while encouraging greater community participation in maintaining public green spaces.

The financial assistance is disbursed through the Delhi Parks and Gardens Society to Resident Welfare Associations (RWAs), non-government organisations (NGOs) and registered societies for upkeep and development of parks.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said strengthening Delhi's green cover remains a priority of the government and the initiative would also help improve the urban environment and strengthen pollution control.

Acknowledging rising maintenance costs and higher labour wages, the government has proposed increasing annual maintenance support from Rs 2.55 lakh per acre to Rs 3.8 lakh per acre, the statement said.

Officials said the hike is aimed at ensuring better cleanliness, irrigation and preservation of greenery in parks across the Capital.

The government is also considering scrapping the existing 90:10 cost-sharing model and replacing it with 100 per cent government funding for eligible projects. Under the present system, organisations are required to contribute 10 per cent of the total project cost.

Officials said the proposed shift is expected to encourage greater participation from smaller RWAs and local bodies that often face financial constraints.

The Delhi government has also proposed increasing one-time financial assistance for development of new parks from Rs 1 lakh per acre to Rs 2.9 lakh per acre, particularly in newly developed colonies and densely populated areas where green spaces are limited.

The statement said the government is also considering one-time grants of up to Rs 2.5 lakh per acre for upgrading existing parks. The assistance may be used for facilities such as display boards, dustbins and irrigation pipelines.

Officials said the proposed measures are expected to make parks cleaner, more organised and environmentally sustainable while improving access to quality public green spaces.

Gupta said long-term upkeep of public spaces is only possible with active community involvement and the proposed measures are designed to empower RWAs and local organisations to take greater responsibility in maintaining neighbourhood parks.

Delhi govt tightens dust control norms

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has made it mandatory for all construction and demolition (C&D) sites in the national capital to use high-density dust screens, as a step to strengthen dust pollution control measures, officials said on Monday.

The Delhi Pollution Control Committee (DPCC) has issued directions that the minimum thickness of green nets to be used at C&D sites has to be 100 GSM (grams per square metre), and all project proponents must comply with the specification with immediate effect, officials added.

Delhi Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa said, "Delhi's fight against air pollution is being pursued with urgency, seriousness and a whole-of-government approach. We are working on all fronts policy changes, scientific interventions, technology-backed monitoring, and stronger enforcement to create a robust protective shield against air pollution in Delhi."

The decision, officials added, has been taken in view of the substantial contribution of construction and demolition activities to dust pollution and follows directions issued by the Commission for Air Quality Management (CAQM), which laid down guidelines for dust pollution control and inspection SOPs for construction and demolition projects. According to the government, earlier norms required construction sites to install tarpaulin covers or green nets around under-construction structures and over stored construction material, but no minimum technical specification had been prescribed for the nets.

With the new order, the government has fixed 100 GSM as the minimum standard to ensure that dust barriers are effective in containing particulate matter such as PM2.5 and PM10 at the source.

Sirsa said, "High-density dust screens are essential for effective dust containment. By prescribing a minimum 100 GSM standard, the government is ensuring that dust mitigation at construction sites is practical, measurable and enforceable."

"The Delhi government is committed to ensuring that every anti-pollution norm translates into visible action at the site level," Sirsa added.

The government is also working on "Dust Portal 2.0", a centralised digital platform aimed at monitoring and regulating construction and demolition sites across Delhi.

Registration of C&D sites on the dust portal has already been made mandatory and officials said the upgraded platform would improve compliance tracking, transparency and enforcement.

The DPCC has issued directions for implementation of the order to agencies including the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, New Delhi Municipal Council, Delhi Development Authority, Delhi Metro Rail Corporation, Central Public Works Department and the Public Works Department for immediate compliance.

MISSION CLEAN YAMUNA

Delhi Water Minister Parvesh Verma and Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa review CETPs and discuss measures to curb industrial pollution and strengthen Yamuna cleaning efforts, in New Delhi, on Monday PTI

Delhi EV Policy gets public backing

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has received an overwhelming response to the Draft Delhi EV Policy 2026, with nearly 700 stakeholders participating in the month-long public consultation process conducted by the Transport Department.

The draft policy remained in the public domain till May 10, inviting suggestions from citizens, industry representatives and institutions. The government also held extensive consultations with electric vehicle manufacturers, charge point operators, battery swapping companies, DISCOMs, fleet aggregators and other stakeholders connected to the EV ecosystem.

Delhi Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh said the large participation reflected growing public support for clean mobility. "The overwhelming response received from citizens, industry stakeholders, institutions and experts reflects Delhi's collective aspiration towards a cleaner, greener and future-ready mobility ecosystem," he said.

According to officials, around 400 submissions came from the general public, including commuters, RWAs, students, delivery riders and vehicle owners. Nearly 200 responses were received from industry stakeholders such as OEMs, battery recyclers, charge point operators and vehicle scrappers.

More than 50 suggestions were also submitted by schools, NGOs, universities, environmental groups and policy organisations, while several government departments and statutory bodies also participated in the consultation process.

The minister said the government, under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, is committed to creating a "progressive and implementation-oriented EV policy" aimed at accelerating electric vehicle adoption and strengthening sustainable urban mobility.

He added that constructive suggestions received during consultations are being examined carefully and suitable recommendations will be incorporated to make the final policy more inclusive, practical and future-ready.

Mayor inspects Badli area, flags civic issues

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Municipal Corporation of Delhi Mayor Pravesh Wahi on Monday conducted an extensive inspection of the Badli area in the Civil Lines Zone and expressed strong displeasure over poor sanitation conditions, unattended debris, and garbage accumulation in several localities.

Accompanied by senior civic officials, the Mayor visited multiple spots in the area, interacted with residents, and directed authorities to resolve public grievances on priority. Taking serious note of the deteriorating sanitation conditions, Wahi reprimanded officials and sanitation staff, warning that negligence in maintaining cleanliness and civic services would not be tolerated.

In a symbolic gesture aimed at stressing accountability, the Mayor personally supervised debris removal operations and also picked up garbage during the inspection. He directed sanitation workers to immediately begin cleaning operations and ensure timely removal of waste and debris from the locality.

Wahi also interacted with traders and shopkeepers, urging them to place dustbins outside their establishments and cooperate in maintaining cleanliness. He said making Delhi clean was a shared responsibility between civic authorities and citizens.

Among those present during the inspection were MLA Deepak Chaudhary, councillor Gayatri Yadav, and Deputy Commissioner Shashi Pratap Singh, along with senior MCD officials.

SEXUAL ASSAULT ON TODDLER

Govt may takeover mgmt of JANAKPURI pvt school

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government may take over the management a private school in west Delhi's Janakpuri as a show-cause notice to the school authorities over the alleged rape of a three-year-old girl on its premises is still unanswered, officials said on Monday.

Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood told PTI that education department officials visited the school on Monday and collected relevant documents which will be verified on Tuesday, and further actions fill follow.

"DoE officials were in the school today; they inspected the school premises to assess safety measures and collected documents which will be verified on Tuesday, and accordingly actions will be taken," he said.

The minister further said the government may approach the court to takeover management of the school if the documents are found to be unsatisfactory.

Citing serious lapses in child safety, supervision and compliance with statutory norms, the Directorate of Education (DoE) on May 8 issued a show-cause notice to the school management, warning that failure to furnish a satisfactory response could lead to withdrawal of recognition and takeover of management under provisions of the Delhi School Education Act and Rules (DSEAR).

The school authorities were granted a three-day period to file its response. However, it is yet to be received by the DoE, and the department is planning to initiate disciplinary action against the school over the alleged deficiencies in child safety measures, officials said.

According to police, the child's mother lodged a complaint at Janakpuri police station on May 1, alleging that her daughter was sexually assaulted during school hours on April 30, the second day after her admission to the school.

A 57-year-old staff member of the school was arrested in this connection.

Police said the child complained of pain after returning home and later told her mother that she had been taken to an isolated area inside the school where the accused allegedly assaulted her.

In its notice dated May 8, the DoE said a preliminary inquiry found several violations and deficiencies on part of the school administration.

The department alleged that the school failed to maintain adequate surveillance and monitoring systems, including non-installation or absence of CCTV cameras at sensitive locations.

It also flagged alleged failures in implementation of child protection safeguards and preventive mechanisms within the campus.

The notice further stated that nursery and pre-primary classes were allegedly being run from a separate private premises located around one kilometre from the recognised main campus without prior approval from authorities. PTI

Census 2027: 93K submit details under self-enumeration

NEW DELHI: Under the ongoing self-enumeration exercise of Census 2027 in the national capital, over 93,000 persons submitted details till Monday, with most entries registered by north east, south west and north west Delhi district residents, officials said. According to official data, 93,521 self-enumerations have been recorded, including 77,372 completed cases and 16,149 initiated cases, taking the overall completion rate to 82.73 per cent.

North East district topped the list with 16,146 self-enumerations, followed by South West with 15,086 and North West with 14,775. West district recorded 10,146 total self-enumerations, while East registered 8,763 cases. The topmost districts are those with the highest population according to Census 2011.

The lowest self-enumeration numbers came from Outer North (545), Old Delhi (566), Central North (1,149), North (3,348), Central (4,042), South East (5,614), South (6,429) and New Delhi district (6,912).

Most of the low-performing districts have lower population and three of them — Outer North, Old Delhi and Central North — were recently created.

In terms of completion percentage, Outer North district led with 87.16 per cent completion of self-enumerations, followed by Central North at 84.42 per cent, North East at 84.31 per cent and West at 84.30 per cent.

The officials said the figures reflected steady progress across most districts, with a majority of them maintaining completion levels above 82 per cent.

Data showed that New Delhi district had the lowest completion percentage at 75.22 per cent, closely followed by Old Delhi at 75.62 per cent. North district recorded 80.91 per cent completion.

Among high-volume districts, North East completed 13,612 cases out of a total of 16,146, while South West completed 12,642 out of 15,086 and North West completed 12,257 out of 14,775. MPOST

Maximum temp settles at 37.5°C

NEW DELHI: Delhi witnessed a relatively cloudy day on Monday, with the maximum temperature settling below the seasonal norm across most parts of the region and the IMD issuing a yellow alert for rain and thunderstorms for Tuesday. According to the weather department, the Safdarjung station, considered the official marker for the Capital, recorded a maximum of 37.5 degrees Celsius, two degrees Celsius below normal. Earlier, the minimum temperature stood at 27.1 degrees Celsius, a slight departure from the usual. The Indian Meteorological Department (IMD) has issued a yellow alert predicting thunderstorms with rain in the city for Tuesday. Palam and Ayanagar both reported similar conditions, with maximum temperatures of 36.7 and 37.2 degrees Celsius, respectively — both below normal. The Ridge and Lodi Road stations also logged below-average highs, at 36.8 degrees Celsius each.

Earlier, Lodhi Road and Ayanagar had registered warmer-than-usual mornings at 26.4 degrees Celsius each, departures of 2.4 and 1.5 degrees, respectively. MPOST

MODI'S FIRST DESTINATION WILL BE UAE

PM to embark on 5-nation trip to UAE, 4 European countries this week

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi will undertake a six-day visit to the United Arab Emirates (UAE), the Netherlands, Sweden, Norway and Italy beginning Friday to further deepen India's bilateral ties amid the ongoing geopolitical upheavals.

PM Modi's first destination will be the UAE, where he will meet President Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan with an aim to advance the bilateral comprehensive strategic partnership and exchange views on the West Asia conflict.

"The two leaders will have the opportunity to exchange views on bilateral issues, in particular energy cooperation, as well as regional and international issues of mutual interest," the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Monday.

It said the visit will serve to promote the significant trade and investment linkages between the two countries.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi PTI

Highlights

- The UAE is India's third-largest trade partner and its seventh-largest source of investment cumulatively over the past 25 years
- In the second leg of his trip, Modi will visit the Netherlands from May 15 to 17. This will be his second trip to the Netherlands, following his visit in 2017

The UAE is India's third-largest trade partner and its seventh-largest source of investment cumulatively over the past 25 years. With the UAE hosting over 4.5 million-strong Indian community, the visit will also be an opportunity to discuss their welfare, the MEA said.

In the second leg of his trip, Modi will visit the Netherlands from May 15 to 17. This will be his second trip to the Netherlands, following his visit in 2017.

The prime minister will meet King Willem-Alexander and Queen Maxima, and hold talks with Prime Minister Rob Jetten.

PM Modi's visit will build on the momentum of high-level engagements and close cooperation spanning diverse sectors, including defence, security, innovation, green hydrogen, semiconductors and a strategic partnership on water, according to the MEA.

The Netherlands is one of India's largest trade destinations in Europe, with bilateral trade worth USD 27.8 billion in 2024-25. The European nation is India's fourth-largest investor with cumulative foreign direct investment of USD 55.6 billion.

From the Netherlands, the prime minister will travel to Sweden at the invitation of his Swedish counterpart Ulf Kristersson for a two-day trip from May 17 to 18.

The prime minister is scheduled to hold bilateral talks with PM Kristersson to review the entire gamut of bilateral relations and explore new avenues of cooperation to enhance bilateral trade, which has reached USD 7.75 billion in 2025.

In their talks, the two sides are set to focus on boosting bilateral ties in areas of green transition, AI, emerging technologies, startups, resilient supply chains, defence, space, climate action and people-to-people ties.

"The two prime ministers will also address the European Round Table for Industry, a leading pan-European business leaders forum, along with Ursula von der Leyen, President of the European Commission," the MEA said in a statement.

In the fourth leg of his visit, Modi will be in Norway from May 18 to 19 to attend the third India-Nordic summit as well as to hold bilateral talks with the leadership of the country.

CJI Surya Kant announces 'One Case One Data' initiative

Launches 'Artificial Intelligence' chatbot 'Su Sahay'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Monday announced the launch of a major digital initiative aimed at strengthening judicial data integration and improving public access to court services across the country.

Making the announcement at the outset of the day's proceedings, the CJI said the judiciary is commencing the "One Case One Data" initiative, which will integrate multi-level information from all the high courts, district courts and taluka courts into a unified system.

"We are commencing the 'one case one data' initiative with multi-level information of all high courts, district and taluka court details embedded. We look forward to developing an efficient case management system," the CJI said.

The initiative is expected to streamline case management by creating a more comprehensive and interconnected digital database across the country's courts.

The CJI said the chatbot has been developed by the National Informatics Centre (NIC) in collaboration with the Supreme Court Registry

The CJI also announced the launch of "Su Sahay", an Artificial Intelligence-powered assistance chatbot integrated with the Supreme Court website to facilitate easier access to justice and court-related services for litigants.

The CJI said the chatbot has been developed by the National Informatics Centre (NIC) in collaboration with the Supreme Court Registry.

"We are also launching 'Su Sahay', an assistance chatbot for our website, developed by the NIC in collaboration with the Registry. This will provide a simple and convenient interface for citizens to seek front-end guidelines and guidance in accessing essential services of the Supreme Court," he said.

He expressed appreciation for the efforts of the Registry officials and Bar members in supporting the digital initiatives.

"My best wishes to the Registry and to the officers who have done this commendable job. I am quite confident that these initiatives will prove beneficial for all stakeholders," the CJI added.

Chhattisgarh constable ends life in Dhamtari over marital dispute

OUR CORRESPONDENT

DHAMTARI: A 35-year-old Chhattisgarh Armed Force (CAF) constable, who had just returned from poll duty in West Bengal, allegedly committed suicide at his rented house in Chhattisgarh's Dhamtari city, apparently following a dispute with his wife, police said.

Constable Jageshwar Prasad Thakur was found hanging from the ceiling of his room in Sapna Pink City colony in the wee hours of Monday, a police official said.

The cop had been serving with the 10th Battalion of the CAF since 2009 and recently returned from election duty in West Bengal. After returning to his home state, he had come to his home on leave, said Rajesh Jagat, Station House Officer of City Kotwali police station.

Originally a resident of Bhatgaon village in neighbouring Balod district, Thakur had been living in the rented accommodation in Dhamtari with his family for the past nine years. He is survived by his wife and three children, the official said.

The deceased cop's younger brother, Tribhuvan, told reporters that Thakur and his wife had an argument on Sunday evening over some issue following which his sister-in-law left home in a huff.

Centre sets July 1 for roll-out of VB-G RAM G Act

Continued from Page 1

The Centre has said the transition will be carried out without disruption to workers or ongoing projects. "Ongoing works… shall be saved and carried over to the new framework seamlessly," the notification said, adding that incomplete public assets and projects already underway will be prioritised for completion.

Under the new framework, every rural household with adult members willing to undertake unskilled manual work will be entitled to 125 days of guaranteed employment in a financial year. As before, employment must be provided within a specified period of demand, failing which workers will remain eligible for unemployment allowance payable by state governments.

Wage payments will continue to be routed through Direct Benefit Transfer into bank or post office accounts. The government has said payments will be made weekly or within 15 days of the closure of muster rolls, with provisions for compensation in case of delays. It has also clarified that workers will not be denied employment due to pending e-KYC verification.

As part of the transition, existing job cards linked to verified e-KYC will remain valid until new "Gramin Rozgar Guarantee Cards" are issued. Workers who are not yet registered will continue to be able to apply through gram panchayats. The Centre has also indicated that new works can be opened during the transition phase if ongoing projects are insufficient to meet labour demand.

One of the central features of the new law is the introduction of "Viksit Gram Panchayat Plans" (VGPPs), which will function as local development blueprints prepared by gram panchayats and approved by gram sabhas. The government has said that all works under the programme will be drawn from these plans to ensure that projects are aligned with local needs and implemented in a saturation-focused manner.

The categories of permissible works have been reorganised into four broad areas: water security, core rural infrastructure, livelihood-related infrastructure and projects aimed at mitigating extreme weather impacts. Officials have said this reflects an increased focus on climate-related challenges and long-term asset creation in rural areas.

Administrative changes under the law include the use of face authentication-based attendance at worksites, although exemptions will be allowed in cases of poor connectivity or technical difficulties. The framework also allows states to restrict work during peak agricultural seasons to prevent labour shortages during sowing and harvesting.

Funding patterns will vary across regions, with northeastern and Himalayan states following a 90:10 Centre-state sharing ratio, other states and Union Territories with legislatures adopting a 60:40 formula, and Union Territories without legislatures receiving full central funding. The material component of expenditure has been capped at 40 percent at the district level.

For 2026-27, the Centre has allocated Rs 95,692.31 crore for the programme, describing it as the highest-ever budget estimate for a rural employment scheme. With expected contributions from states, the total outlay is projected to exceed Rs 1.51 lakh crore.

The government has argued that the framework represents a shift toward a more structured and development-linked model of rural employment, moving beyond a purely demand-driven wage programme to one that combines livelihood support with infrastructure creation and climate resilience.

However, the decision to replace the earlier law has drawn criticism from opposition parties and labour rights groups, who note that the previous programme had evolved into a rights-based social protection system. Concerns have been raised about the potential impact of increased digitisation, including face authentication requirements, particularly in areas with limited connectivity and among elderly workers.

Critics have also pointed to the shift toward normative allocation of funds, warning that any expenditure beyond allocated limits may need to be borne by state governments. Questions have been raised about whether the enhanced 125-day employment guarantee will be supported by adequate financial resources, especially in light of past concerns over wage payment delays.

There are also apprehensions about the provision allowing restrictions on work during peak agricultural seasons, with some arguing that it could limit earning opportunities for landless labourers.

Despite these concerns, the Centre has maintained that the transition will be "seamless and uninterrupted", with continuity in worker entitlements and safeguards such as unemployment allowance and compensation for delayed wage payments remaining in place. Draft rules covering wage payments, grievance redressal, administrative provisions and other operational aspects are currently being finalised in consultation with states and are expected to be released for public consultation.

From Page 1

India has sufficient

of long-term planning, Mittal said expanding them to cover 90 days of consumption would require significant capital. "For a country like India which consumes 5 million barrels a day, to have a 90-day reserve would be putting a lot of money in a box without using it at all," he said, adding that the government is exploring commercial models that allow stored crude to generate returns.

Parallel to the government's supply management efforts, Modi has urged citizens to play a role in easing pressure on the economy. Speaking at a public event in Vadodara, the Prime Minister called for reduced fuel consumption and greater reliance on public transport and electric vehicles. He also suggested reviving work-from-home practices where feasible and limiting non-essential foreign travel.

"The West Asia crisis is one of the worst in the decade. Just as we overcame the COVID-19 pandemic, we will come out of this also," Modi said, appealing for collective responsibility.

He further asked citizens to cut down on imports and avoid discretionary spending that drains foreign exchange reserves. In particular, Modi urged people to postpone gold purchases, noting that large volumes of foreign currency are used to import the precious metal.

"We must make every effort to reduce the use of imported products and avoid personal activities that involve spending foreign currency," he said.

The Prime Minister's remarks, delivered a day after a similar appeal in Telangana, signal a broader push for economic prudence amid external uncertainties. While some observers have interpreted the messaging as a precursor to possible price adjustments, officials have maintained that there is no immediate plan to alter fuel pricing or introduce rationing.

Government sources reiterated that India remains relatively stable compared to several countries that have imposed stricter demand controls or rationing measures. "Government uses all sorts of tools," Mittal said, describing India as "a relative oasis of calm" in a volatile global energy environment.

With global conditions still uncertain, authorities continue to balance supply security, fiscal pressures and consumer protection, while encouraging behavioural changes to reduce dependence on imports.

Bengal BJP

concerns over demographic changes.

"Our country's security, West Bengal's security, and the way demographic patterns have changed — these are serious concerns. On the very first day, we approved the land transfer process for the Union Home Ministry and the BSF to strengthen border security," he said.

Highlighting the urgency of the matter, the Chief Minister said the process would begin immediately.

"The land transfer process begins today itself. The Chief Secretary and the Land and Revenue Secretary have been instructed to ensure that the required land is handed over to the BSF within 45 days. This was a commitment made by the Union Home Minister before the elections, and today we fulfilled it in our very first Cabinet meeting," he said.

The Chief Minister also launched a sharp attack on the previous government, alleging that political considerations had delayed border security measures.

"Whatever land the BSF requires will be provided. The Land Department has already completed much of the groundwork. The previous government deliberately prevented the department from functioning because they wanted to protect certain vote banks and illegal infiltrators from outside India. Even the directives of the Calcutta High Court were ignored, which no government should ever do," he alleged.

He further said the present administration would ensure accountability and factual accuracy in governance.

"We have already instructed the Land Department to begin transferring ready land immediately. From the information I had earlier as Leader of the Opposition, nearly 90 per cent of the land could have been transferred long ago. But a Chief Minister must speak responsibly and ensure complete authenticity in every statement. Unlike the previous government, this administration will not indulge in casual or irresponsible remarks," he said.

Meanwhile, Adhikari accused the former Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress government of "betraying" Bengal, India and its Constitution by allegedly stalling the Census process and failing to implement the new criminal laws enacted by Parliament.

He confirmed that Bengal would now officially function under the new criminal law (BNS, BNSS & BSA) regime from Monday, with all police and legal procedures shifting to the updated framework.

No power

Despite these challenges, India did not yield, he added, pointing out that two more tests were carried out on May 13, 1998, signalling what he called an unwavering political will.

"Anyone else would have faltered… But we are built differently," Modi said, crediting the Vajpayee-led government for standing firm in the face of pressure. "No power on earth can make India bow down or succumb to pressure," he added.

The Prime Minister also reflected on the symbolic importance of Somnath, describing its reconstruction as a marker of India's cultural resurgence after Independence. He said the 1951 consecration represented a "proclamation of India's liberated consciousness" following freedom in 1947. The ongoing Amrut Mahotsav, he noted, is not just a remembrance of the past but a source of inspiration for the country's future.

During his address, Modi criticised what he termed as "forces" that place appeasement politics above national self-respect. He drew parallels with opposition faced during the construction of the Ram Temple, saying similar attitudes had surfaced in debates around cultural and religious heritage.

Referring to the history of Somnath, Modi said the temple had been destroyed multiple times by invaders but was rebuilt repeatedly, reflecting resilience. He credited leaders such as Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel and India's first President Rajendra Prasad for their role in rebuilding the shrine, while noting that they faced opposition from then Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru.

He said issues related to national identity had often been subject to political contestation in India, adding that such debates should give way to a balanced approach combining development with cultural preservation. "In India, heritage and modernity go hand in hand," he said.

Earlier in the day, Modi performed Maha Pooja and other rituals at the temple. He also held a roadshow along a 1.5-km route from the helipad to Veer Hamirji Circle, where crowds gathered to greet him with flags and slogans. Cultural performances by artists from across the country, including West Bengal, were held along the route as part of the celebrations.

Cracks in AIADMK

Signs of revolt against party chief Edappadi K Palaniswami were also visible.

With all the political parties having already elected their respective legislative party leaders, the AIADMK is yet to choose its floor leader due to the rift within the party.

The internal fight could be visible as the AIADMK legislators came to the Assembly on Monday in two groups, one headed by former minister S P Velumani and another led by Palaniswami.

While a group of AIADMK MLAs, led by Thalavai Sundaram, gave a letter to the protem speaker Karuppiah seeking to declare their party's general secretary Palaniswami as the legislature party leader. The rebel group, led by Velumani, gave another letter, demanding that the protem speaker recognise C V Shanmugam as the floor leader of their party.

Sources said that the Sundaram-led group that supports Palaniswami consisted of 17 MLAs, while the Velumani-led group that supports Shanmugam as floor leader has the backing of 30 MLAs.

According to AIADMK sources, while one section of the party strongly opposed extending support to the TVK in government formation, another faction advocated providing outside support to the Vijay-led party.

The feud between the AIADMK leaders came to the limelight when rebel group MLAs, including Velumani and Shanmugam, skipped the meetings chaired by Palaniswami soon after the poll debacle.

Party insiders said Shanmugam, Velumani and their supporters have shown interest in backing the TVK.

"There is a clear split within the party. Many MLAs want a change in leadership. If Palaniswami continues as a leader, there is a possibility of some MLAs extending support to the TVK," said former AIADMK leader K C Palanisamy.

He further said that Palaniswami should "voluntarily step down" from the party's top post so that it can reunite and face the next election.

The party's internal turmoil emerged at a tough period for the AIADMK, which had successive electoral defeats, including the 2019 parliament election, the 2021 Assembly election, the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, and the 2021 Assembly election. In addition, the party also lost the Erode by-election in 2025.

For the first time in recent history, it was reported that MLAs arrived at the assembly in two separate groups to take their oaths.

The divided stance could severely impact the party's future in Tamil Nadu politics.

BJP's victory

if the winning margin was lower than the number of voters unable to cast ballots, the issue may require judicial scrutiny. "Suppose margin is 2% and 15% of the electorate who are mapped could not vote, then maybe, we are not expressing any opinion, but we would definitely have to apply our minds," he had said.

Senior advocate Kalyan Bandhopadhyay, appearing for the TMC, submitted that in 31 constituencies, the BJP's winning margin was lower than the number of electors whose names had been deleted and kept under adjudication during the SIR process. In one Constituency, he said, the margin of defeat was 862 votes while more than 5432 persons had been removed from the electoral rolls for adjudication.

Bandhopadhyay further claimed that nearly 35 lakh appeals against deletions were pending before the appellate tribunals and said the overall vote gap between the BJP and the TMC was nearly 32 lakh votes.

During the hearing, Bandhopadhyay also informed the court that former High Court Chief Justice T.S. Sivagnanam had resigned as a member of the appellate tribunal. The matter was later adjourned.

MEA

FactCheck said in its post.

During the briefing, Jaiswal was also asked about the upcoming meeting of the foreign ministers of BRICS member nations and other countries under India's chairmanship.

"Your question was about Iran's foreign minister... See, we have the BRICS foreign ministers meeting to be held in New Delhi. For this, we expect foreign ministers from member countries of BRICS, as well as partner countries of BRICS, to join us. We shall keep you updated as to who the leaders are who will be here," Jaiswal said.

He also reiterated India's stand on the West Asia conflict and asserted that dialogue and diplomacy are the way forward to restore peace in the region.

EC set to roll

The clean-up effort has already covered around 60 crore of India's nearly 99 crore registered voters. The upcoming phase will target the remaining nearly 40 crore electors across 17 states and five Union Territories, completing the nationwide revision.

On February 19, the poll authority had directed 22 states and Union Territories, including Delhi, to expedite preparatory work, noting that the exercise was expected to begin from April. Once phase three is completed, all states and Union Territories will have undergone the revision process.

In a communication to chief electoral officers of states and Union Territories such as Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Haryana, Jammu and Kashmir, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Delhi, Odisha and others, the Commission reiterated that a pan-India SIR had been ordered in June last year. However, the exercise has seen multiple adjustments to its schedule due to various administrative and legal factors.

In Bihar, for instance, political parties approached the Supreme Court challenging aspects of the SIR conducted in Tamil Nadu and West Bengal. In West Bengal, Trinamool Congress president Mamata Banerjee had also appealed before the Chief Justice of India, raising concerns over the roll revision in the state.

The process has also drawn political scrutiny. During preparations in Bihar, election officials claimed that grassroots functionaries had identified individuals from Bangladesh, Nepal and Myanmar in voter lists. However, no detailed figures or supporting evidence were later released by the Commission. Opposition parties described these claims as an attempt to target certain voter groups.

Data released by the Commission and state officials show that the SIR has led to a significant reduction in electoral rolls. Across nine states and three Union Territories, voter lists were reduced by 10.2 per cent following the exercise. Over 60 lakh deceased voters were removed, including 25.47 lakh from Uttar Pradesh and 24.16 lakh from West Bengal.

Additionally, 63.16 lakh names were deleted after objections and adjudication during the revision process. When phase II was announced on October 27, the total voter base across 12 states and Union Territories stood at more than 50.99 crore. After completion, the number declined to 45.81 crore, marking a reduction of over 5.18 crore electors.

With phase II now concluded and final electoral rolls published for 10 states and three Union Territories, the Commission is moving ahead to complete the nationwide revision through its upcoming phase.

AUSTERITY APPEAL ROW

Oppn attacks PM on govt's failures

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Opposition leaders on Monday attacked Prime Minister Narendra Modi alleging that his government had failed to safeguard people's interests and dubbed him a "compromised PM" after he made an appeal for judicious use of fuel and defer gold purchases as well as foreign travel to help save foreign exchange in the wake of the West Asia crisis.

The BJP, however, defended Modi saying his appeal for austerity was in the larger national interest and should be followed by everyone.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge and former party chief Rahul Gandhi went on the offensive and alleged that the "compromised PM" was no longer capable of running the country and asked Modi not to shift the blame for "12 years of failures" onto the shoulders of ordinary Indians.

Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said the PM's words were "evidence of failure".

Highlights

» Rahul Gandhi said the PM's words were 'evidence of failure'

» BJP, however, defended Modi saying his appeal for austerity was in the larger national interest

» Akhilesh Yadav alleged that the BJP govt had failed in handling both the economy and foreign policy

"These are not words of counsel; they are evidence of failure," he said.

"Time and again, they shift the responsibility onto the public to evade their own accountability," Gandhi said, adding, "The compromised PM is no longer capable of running the country."

Congress chief Kharge said that at a time when people were struggling under the weight of adversity, the prime minister was busy lecturing the country on the virtues of saving.

He questioned why the Prime Minister was so engrossed in election campaigning and conducting roadshows.

Union minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said the appeal was aimed at guiding and inspiring people to conserve fuel, a limited resource.

"His suggestions are in the larger national and public interest, and all of us should follow them. This is what visionary leadership means, always thinking about the nation and its people, and guiding the country through every crisis," Chouhan said.

Seeking to defend the PM's remarks, BJP leader Sudhanshu Trivedi said what Modi had said was the duty of the government and it was similar to how the government advises caution when there is a possibility of a tsunami or a storm.

"I think the Opposition is once again making the mistake of opposing the government, the BJP and PM Narendra Modi to the extent that it risks crossing into opposing the nation," Trivedi said.

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav alleged that the BJP government had failed in handling both the economy and foreign policy, calling its appeal an "admission of failure".

In a post on X, Yadav said, "As soon as elections are over, the government suddenly remembered the 'crisis'. In reality, there is only one crisis for the country and its name is BJP."

The former Uttar Pradesh chief minister questioned how the country would achieve the goal of becoming a "five trillion dollar economy" if the government was forced to impose several restrictions.

"It appears the BJP government has completely lost control," he said, adding that such statements from the government could create panic in the markets and the public.

Shiv Sena (UBT) leader Priyanka Chaturvedi alleged that the austerity measures were a result of election-focused governance and the NCP (SP) said the BJP should "lead by example" before asking the public to curtail consumption and travel.

CPIM general secretary MA Baby condemned the PM's call for austerity and said it was ironic that the Prime Minister called upon the people to implement austerity measures.

"The government has utterly failed to safeguard the interests of the people because of its decision to completely align with the US-Israel axis," he alleged.

"The PM's statement itself proves that all is not well with the economy," he said, as he questioned the timing of the remarks.

CPI leader D Raja asked, "Who is buying gold? Whom is the Prime Minister advising? Let him say who is buying gold. He is advising people not to buy gold, but people do not even have enough money to eat. They do not have money in their hands, so how can they buy gold? What is the Prime Minister saying?"

AAP MP Sanjay Singh said the PM should stop doing roadshows, holding public rallies and going on foreign trips to save fuel.

Stage set for Himanta to take oath as Assam CM for 2nd term

Prime Minister and top NDA leaders to attend event

MPOST BUREAU

Security personnel inspect the venue ahead of the swearing-in ceremony of Assam CM-elect Himanta Biswa Sarma, in Guwahati, Monday PTI

GUWAHATI: The stage is set for Himanta Biswa Sarma to take oath as Assam chief minister for a second consecutive term on Tuesday, marking the start of the BJP-led NDA government's third straight tenure in the state.

The swearing-in ceremony at the Veterinary College Field in Khanapara is expected to witness the presence of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home minister Amit Shah, Defence minister Rajnath Singh, Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman, Union minister Sarbananda Sonowal and BJP national president Nitin Nabin, along with over 40 NDA chief ministers and deputy chief ministers.

Governor Lakshman Prasad Acharya, who on Sunday appointed Sarma as the chief minister, will administer the oath of office and secrecy to the BJP leader and members of the new Council of Ministers at 11:40 am.

Sarma, who first became chief minister in 2021, will be the first non-Congress leader in Assam to serve two consecutive terms as CM.

This will be the NDA's third consecutive term in the state since the BJP-led alliance first came to power in 2016 under then CM Sarbananda Sonowal.

The NDA, comprising the BJP, Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) and Bodoland People's Front (BPF), secured a sweeping mandate in the Assembly polls, winning a record 102 seats in the 126-member House.

The BJP alone bagged 82, its first single-party majority in the state, while AGP and BPF won 10 seats each.

AHEAD OF 2027 PUNJAB POLLS

Punjab CM's cousin Gian Singh Mann joins BJP

SWATI MAHAJAN

CHANDIGARH: As Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann's cousin brother Gyan Singh Mann joins the saffron party, Bhartiya Janta Party, few months before state Assembly polls, it sends strong signals about changing shades of Punjab's politics.

Though this might be yet another set back for Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) in Punjab which was still recovering from the setback of seven of its ten Rajya Sabha MPs joining BJP, it displays a shift from alliance-era politics to symbolic politics.

Gyan Singh Mann joined the party in the presence of Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini and BJP Punjab Chief Sunil Jakhar.

Closer Look

» Gyan Singh Mann joined the party in the presence of Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini and BJP Punjab Chief Sunil Jakhar

» The saffron party has been primarily dependent on Shiromani Akali Dal to form government in Punjab for years

» This might be another setback for AAP after seven of its Rajya Sabha MPs joining BJP

It seems that the party has switched its political strategy in Punjab and is aiming an deeper political expansion by symbolism and focussed social outreach.

With the Haryana Chief Minister Saini also proactively contributing to upcoming elections through numerous outreach initiatives, BJPs switch from remaining a coalition partner in the past to an independent political party in the state seems real.

The saffron party has been primarily dependent on Shiromani Akali Dal to form government in Punjab for years.

Hitting on the pulse of the state, where family status, networking in villages often shape political narratives by bringing a relative of the Chief Minister the BJP might be successful in corroborating the internal rift regarding Bhagwant Mann's leadership in AAP.

According to news agency, the Mann-cousin has been a part of the Aam Aadmi Party and played key organisational role in Sangrur and Dhuri. He was in fact associated with the managing the campaign of Bhagwant Mann during his initial political days. Later, he has been vocal in criticising and questioning the decisions of AAP government.

'NEET not exam anymore but auction': Rahul

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Monday attacked the BJP over alleged irregularities in the NEET-UG 2026, with Rahul Gandhi claiming that it is not an exam anymore but an "auction" and that no one poses a greater threat to the dreams of India's youth than the Modi government.

The leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha said he stands with the country's youth in an "incredibly difficult time" and vowed to change the system.

"I heard the news about the NEET 2026 paper leak. It's not an exam anymore --NEET is now an auction. Many questions were being sold on WhatsApp 42 hours before the exam," Gandhi said in a post in Hindi on X.

Over 22 lakh children studied through sleepless nights all year, burning the midnight oil, and in one night, their future was openly "auctioned off" in the marketplace, he said.

"This isn't the first time. In 10 years, 89 paper leaks—48 re-exams. Every time, the same promises, and then the same silence," the former Congress chief said.

Punjab: Polling for 105 municipal bodies on May 26, counting on May 29

CHANDIGARH: Polling for 105 municipal bodies in Punjab, including eight municipal corporations, is scheduled for May 26, as announced by State Election Commissioner Raj Kamal Chaudhury on Monday.

Vote counting will take place on May 29. Addressing the media here, Chaudhury shared details about the elections, stating that they will occur in the following eight municipal corporations: Mohali, Bathinda, Abohar, Barnala, Kapurthala, Moga, Batala, and Pathankot.

Additionally, elections will be held for 76 municipal councils and 21 Nagar Panchayats, totalling 2,019 wards across the 105 municipal bodies, he added.

With the announcement of the election schedule, the Model Code of Conduct has come into immediate effect. AGENCIES

TN CM Joseph Vijay, newly elected MLAs take oath in Assembly

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHENNAI: Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay, nine other ministers, former CMs including Edappadi K Palaniswami, ex- deputy CM Udhayanidhi Stalin and the newly elected MLAs on Monday took the oath of office in the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly.

Pro-tem Speaker M V Karuppaiah, praising Vijay's leadership and victory, initiated the proceedings on administration of the oath of office for MLAs in the first session of the 17th Assembly.

The chief minister was the first to take oath as MLA and ministers N Anand, Aadhav Arjuna, KG Arunraj, KA Sengottaiyan, P Venkataramanan, R Nirmalkumar, Rajmohan and TK Prabhu followed suit.

Following this, DMK legislature party leader and former deputy CM Udhayanidhi Stalin, former CMs Palaniswami and O Panneerselvam (DMK), and other MLAs took oath of office.

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay takes oath as Member of the Legislative Assembly (MLA) PTI

Vijay, Udhayanidhi and Panneerselvam were among those who "solemnly affirmed" and took oath.

Palaniswami and PMK's Sowmya Anbumani were among those who took oath in the name of God.

Panrutti AIADMK MLA K Mohan while taking oath suddenly broke down and hailed late chief minister J Jayalalithaa and with folded hands paid tributes to the portrait of the late AIADMK matriarch in the Assembly hall.

Initially, Minister S Keerthana could not take oath of office as MLA as she did not present her Certificate of Election, a prerequisite for taking oath, an official said.

When the Assembly Principal Secretary K Srinivasan invited Keerthana, announcing her name in the microphone, she walked to the podium, which was right in front of the chair of the CM from one side.

Also, MLAs who take oath would face the chair of the pro-tem speaker.

While Keerthana neared the podium, Srinivasan raised his hand and asked her the certificate, which could be seen in the live coverage of the Assembly proceedings.

However, she could not produce the certificate and what she replied to Srinivasan was not known.

Asked what transpired, an official told news agency: "It seems that she did not have her certificate of election with her ready. Since she could not submit the certificate, the senior official politely declined to allow her to take oath. She may take oath whenever she submits her certificate of election."

J&K CM calls on Amit Shah to discuss statehood & business rules for UT

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah called on Union Home minister Amit Shah on Monday where the two leaders discussed issues concerning the Union territory.

Before leaving for the national capital, the chief minister told reporters in Srinagar that he would discuss all the issues concerning Jammu and Kashmir.

"I wish we could have got our statehood after one meeting with the home minister. If that was the case, we would have got it a long time ago. But yes, I will raise statehood, business rules and other issues concerning Jammu and Kashmir in the meeting," he said.

Abdullah also said that there was "nothing wrong" in

Union Home minister Amit Shah being greeted by J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah during a meeting PTI

giving telecom powers to the lieutenant governor (L-G) during public safety events, as he holds the charge of security and law and order.

"This is the right thing. These powers should be with the lieutenant governor. This is not against the business rules or the reorganisation act," the chief minister told reporters.

He said that orders to stop phone services or internet are issued by the home department, which comes under the L-G.

The Centre has last week authorised the Jammu and Kashmir L-G to exercise powers, such as interception of signals, suspension of service and decryption of messages, related to telecom services in the UT during public safety events or national emergency.

According to the order issued on Thursday, the President directed the LG to exercise the powers and discharge the functions of the state government under Sub-Section 20 (2) of the Telecommunications Act, 2023 (44 of 2023), which deals with situations involving public safety and national security, within the UT.

millenniumpost
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HIGH-LEVEL MEETING ON WEST ASIA CRISIS

Measures in place to shield supply chains: Rajnath

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: India has implemented concrete measures to shield supply chains and ensure uninterrupted energy flows amid the escalating West Asia crisis, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said Monday.

Singh, while chairing a high-level meeting of the Informal Group of Ministers (IGoM) set-up to monitor the situation in West Asia, emphasised that the government is prioritising maritime security and economic stability to offset global volatility.

He directed officials to take concrete steps to implement the Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal that included cutting fuel consumption as part of efforts to help conserve India's foreign exchange reserves. The meeting was attended by Chemicals and Fertilisers Minister Jagat Prakash Nadda, Petroleum Minister Hardeep Singh Puri, Railways and Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw, Civil Aviation Minister Kinjarapu Rammohan Naidu, and Ports and Shipping Minister Sarbananda Sonowal, among others.

Defence minister Rajnath Singh chairs the fifth meeting of the Inter-Ministerial Group of Ministers to review risks to energy supply chains and availability of essential commodities, in New Delhi PTI

HIGHLIGHTS

- Singh emphasised that the govt is prioritising the maritime security and economic stability to offset global volatility
- He directed officials to take concrete steps to implement the PM's appeal that included cutting fuel consumption as part of efforts to help conserve foreign exchange reserves

The IGoM was informed that the country is secure, and there is no shortage of any petroleum product, even as most other nations have taken emergency measures to dramatically reduce domestic fuel consumption, the defence ministry said. "India has 60 days of crude oil, 60 days of natural gas and 45 days of LPG rolling stock. The foreign exchange reserves stand at a comfortable USD 703 billion," it said.

"India is the world's third largest oil refiner and fourth largest exporter of petroleum products, exporting to over 150 countries and is meeting domestic demand in full. But there is a huge cost being borne by the nation as international crude prices are continuing at very high levels," it said.

The ministry said fuel conservation can ease this "burden". It said PM Modi's appeal to the people to help the country deal with global economic disruptions, supply chain challenges and rising prices emphasised prudence in usage of petroleum products and reducing wasteful consumption so that the fiscal burden is reduced. The defence minister directed the officials to take concrete steps to implement the prime minister's appeal.

"Ministries and states must identify, in a coordinated manner, measures to institutionalise fuel efficiency, public awareness, and responsible consumption behaviour," said Singh. He urged the people to remain calm and avoid any kind of panic as all concrete steps are being taken to prevent shortages or disruptions in supply chains.

The defence minister emphasised that the primary focus for India during the current phase is to ensure that energy flows remain uninterrupted, economic stability is maintained, and maritime trade routes remain secure.

He also directed all stakeholders to remain vigilant to deal with every situation.

Singh underlined the need to accelerate the process of transforming India's energy mix, rapidly expanding renewable-based alternative sources, and identifying more reliable and diversified supplies.

BENGALURU EVENT

Gelatin sticks near PM's route: NIA joins investigation

Special team comprising nearly 50 officials begins investigation

MPOST BUREAU

REPRESENTATIVE PIC

BENGALURU: A day after gelatin sticks were recovered from a roadside near PM Narendra Modi's programme venue on the outskirts of the city, a team of NIA officials has begun examining the incident, a senior police officer said on Monday.

He said, however, that no arrests have been made so far, adding that the matter is still under investigation.

Police are also scanning CCTV footage along the route to identify who placed the gelatin sticks and to ascertain the motive behind it.

"The National Investigation Agency team is examining the incident from its side, while our detailed investigation is underway. No arrests have been made yet," the senior officer added.

A special investigation team comprising nearly 50 personnel, including four inspectors, has been formed to probe the incident, police said.

A case has been registered at Kaggalipura police station under the provisions of the Explosives Act, they added. According to police, on Sunday morning, two gelatin sticks were discovered during security checks near Tataguni under Kaggalipura police station limits, along a route connected to the PM's movement schedule, nearly three kilometres away from the main venue.

The discovery was made shortly before he arrived in the area as part of extensive route sanitisation.

The incident triggered heightened security measures and an intensive investigation into the origin of the explosives and whether there was any larger conspiracy behind their presence.

INSIGHT

- Police are also scanning CCTV footage along the route to identify who placed the gelatin sticks and to ascertain the motive behind it
- A case has been registered at Kaggalipura police station under the provisions of the Explosives Act

Modi was in Bengaluru to attend the 45th Foundation Day celebrations at the Art of Living Foundation centre on Kanakapura Road near Kaggalipura.

The recovery came amid a seven-layer security arrangement for the PM's visit, with police and security agencies conducting route inspections for nearly a week in advance.

Modi landed at HAL Airport at around 10.25 am and attended a programme near the airport before travelling by helicopter to the Art of Living venue, where he participated in an event alongside spiritual leader Sri Sri Ravi Shankar.

Chamba: 5 Guj tourists among 6 dead after car falls into gorge

SHIMLA: Six people, including five tourists from Gujarat, were killed while four others sustained serious injuries as the car they were travelling in plunged into a deep gorge at Chamba district's Kakira in the early hours of Monday, police said.

Expressing grief over the incident, Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu directed the district administration to provide all possible assistance to the affected families and ensure the best possible treatment to the injured, a statement issued here said.

The Toyota Innova vehicle, overloaded with 10 people onboard, was on its way from Manali to Dalhousie when the incident occurred on the Lahru-Tunnuhatti road.

THE MISHAP

- The vehicle, with 10 people onboard, was on its way from Manali to Dalhousie when the incident occurred
- The impact of the fall was so intense that parts of the vehicle were scattered all around

The impact of the fall was so intense that parts of the vehicle were scattered all around, police said, adding that they and the rescue teams had difficulty in evacuating the injured persons -- who were referred to the zonal hospital.

The deceased individuals have been identified as Lalit Bhai Phatnani, his wife Mamta, Priyank Kanhaiya Lal, his wife Kajal and son Diyansh, all residents of Gujarat, and driver Jaswant, a resident of Joginder-nagar subdivision in Mandi.

The cause of the accident is yet to be ascertained, but the injured persons said the driver lost control over the vehicle while negotiating a sharp curve, according to officials.

The injured have been admitted to Dr Rajendra Prasad Government Medical College, Tanda in Kangra district, police said.

A case has been registered and further investigations to ascertain the cause that led to the accident are underway, they added. MPOST

Prepaid smart meters: UP govt to refund Rs 200 crore to consumers

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Facing mounting public anger and political pressure over prepaid smart meters, the Uttar Pradesh government has decided to step back from the scheme and refund money collected from consumers.

More than five lakh electricity consumers across the state are set to receive refunds amounting to nearly Rs 200 crore from this month. Officials said the amount will be adjusted directly in consumers' electricity bills.

The move comes after widespread complaints over alleged overcharging in the installation of prepaid smart meters. According to information available, consumers were charged as much as Rs 6,016 for smart meters whose actual cost was around Rs 2,800.

More than 5 lakh electricity consumers are set to receive refunds

The issue triggered protests from consumer groups, trader associations and opposition parties across the state.

Critics alleged that power distribution companies were burdening consumers in the name of prepaid billing and forcing them to pay inflated charges. The opposition had also accused the government of turning electricity services into a profit-driven exercise at the expense of ordinary consumers. Amid growing protests and the changing political atmosphere, the Yogi Adityanath government has now decided to withdraw the prepaid smart meter model for the time being. The decision is being seen as an attempt to defuse public resentment ahead of upcoming political challenges.

Earlier, the state government had already announced that smart meters installed under the Revamped Distribution Sector Scheme would operate in postpaid mode instead of prepaid billing. Consumers are expected to start receiving postpaid electricity bills from June onwards.

Officials maintain that the shift is aimed at addressing consumer concerns and improving transparency in billing, though opposition parties continue to question the implementation of the smart meter project and the higher charges imposed on consumers.

Haryana: Oppn slams govt over sanitation workers' strike

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: With sanitation workers in Haryana continuing their strike in support of various demands, the Opposition on Monday alleged that the state was witnessing a severe sanitation crisis, with garbage piling up across cities and towns, posing serious health risks.

The sanitation workers, under the banner of the Haryana Sarv Karamchari Sangh, announced that their strike would continue till May 14, accusing the state government of failing to address their demands despite repeated appeals.

Former Haryana chief minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda said the sanitation situation across the state had become deplorable.

"Piles of garbage have accumulated everywhere, with waste scattered across roads and streets," Hooda said, alleging that the BJP government remained indifferent to the worsening crisis. He extended support to the striking workers and urged the government to immediately begin talks with employee representatives.

The workers are demanding regularisation of contractual employees, implementation of minimum wages and resolution of long-pending issues related to fire service staff.

Congress general secretary Randeep Singh Surjewala alleged that over 3,500 metric tonnes of garbage was lying unattended in Gurugram alone, creating conditions conducive to the spread of diseases such as dengue and malaria.

Congress leader Brijendra Singh warned that Haryana was on the verge of a health emergency as heaps of garbage continued to accumulate in cities including Gurugram, Hisar and Faridabad.

Meanwhile, Sarv Karamchari Sangh Haryana president Naresh Shastri accused the government of adopting a "stubborn attitude" and confirmed that the Municipal Employees Union had decided to extend the strike till May 14.

Somnath temple a timeless symbol of Sanatan consciousness: Haryana CM

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Monday said that the Somnath temple is not merely a place of worship but a timeless symbol of India's 'Sanatan' consciousness, unwavering faith and national self-respect that has inspired the nation to rise stronger after every invasion, struggle and adversity.

Addressing the state-level 'Somnath Swabhiman Parv' organised at the sacred Shree Sangmeshwar Mahadev temple Arunai in Pehowa in Kurukshetra, Saini said the year-long national celebration marking 75 years of the reconstruction of Somnath temple in Gujarat reflects the spiritual awakening, cultural resurgence and civilisational continuity of India.

During the event, the chief minister and the dignitaries present also watched the live telecast from Somnath temple, where Prime Minister Narendra Modi offered special prayers and addressed the gathering.

Notably, Somnath is one of India's most sacred pilgrimage centres and the first among the twelve Jyotirlingas of Lord Shiva. 'Somnath Swabhiman Parv' marks two significant milestones in India's historical journey: one thousand years since the first recorded attack on the Somnath temple in 1026, and seventy-five years since the reopening of the reconstructed temple in 1951 following Independence.

The Parv highlights the historic significance of the temple and celebrates its enduring legacy. To commemorate this event, Modi visited the Somnath temple on May 11.

In Kurukshetra, beginning his address with chants of 'Har Har Mahadev', Saini said that celebrating the Parv at the holy confluence of the Vedic rivers Arunai and Saraswati further enhanced the spiritual significance of the occasion.

He said the ancient Sangameshwar temple has, for centuries, remained a sacred reminder of this divine confluence and India's rich spiritual heritage.

During the programme, he flagged off a grand 'Kalash Yatra' comprising 101 women. A large number of devotees participated in the procession held amidst a devotional atmosphere.

On the occasion, the chief minister welcomed and felicitated the saints and sages who had specially come from various pilgrimage sites of the Kurukshetra region. He also sought their blessings.

PDP leader Iltija Mufti's X account withheld after sedition case

MPOST BUREAU

SRINAGAR: The account of PDP leader Iltija Mufti on X was withheld in India following a legal demand, nearly two weeks after authorities registered a case of sedition against her for posting a video of former Hurriyat Conference leader Syed Ali Shah Geelani.

"@IltijaMufti_ has been withheld in IN in response to a legal demand," the X page of her account read.

The withholding of the X handle of the young PDP leader comes in the wake of an FIR registered by the cyber police on April 30 after Iltija Mufti had posted a video clip of Geelani on her handle.

MP CM releases two Botswana female cheetahs into Kuno Park

SATYAPRAKASH SHARMA

BHOPAL: Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Monday released two female cheetahs brought from Botswana into the wild at Kuno National Park after completion of their quarantine period.

"Today, two female cheetahs brought from Botswana were released in Palpur-Kuno National Park, Sheopur. The total number of cheetahs in India has now reached 57, including 37 born in India, marking an important milestone for Project Cheetah and wildlife conservation," Yadav said.

Calling it a matter of pride for Madhya Pradesh, the Chief Minister said Kuno National Park was emerging as a key centre for biodiversity conservation under Project Cheetah. In a post on X, he credited Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Minister Bhupender Yadav for steering the ambitious conservation initiative.

Project Cheetah aims to restore the endangered species in India, increase its population and eventually prepare the animals for free-ranging survival and hunting in the wild.

Nine cheetahs — six females and three males — were brought from Botswana to Kuno in February this year and kept in smaller enclosures to help them adapt to local conditions. The release marks the third major international phase of Project Cheetah. The project was launched by PM Modi on September 17, 2022, with the release of eight cheetahs brought from Namibia, followed by the arrival of 12 cheetahs from South Africa in 2023.

Officials said the two female cheetahs from the Botswana batch were released into the open forest area near the Kuno river system. After releasing the animals, the Chief Minister toured the national park.

INDIA-AFRICA FORUM SUMMIT

India eyes deeper Africa ties amid global uncertainties

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The upcoming 4th India-Africa Forum Summit is seen as having strategic and bilateral importance amid the ongoing conflict in West Asia – resulting in a crisis and significant implications for the Global South. India's renewed outreach to Africa reflects a significant shift in New Delhi's foreign policy priorities – one that increasingly recognises the African continent not merely as a development partner.

Ahead of the important summit, government officials emphasise the current economic realities and at the centre of this engagement lies a clear economic objective - trade, investment, energy security and connectivity. Bilateral trade crossing USD 85 billion and investments nearing USD 80 billion indicate that the relationship has acquired substantial economic depth. More importantly, India appears keen to expand beyond traditional sectors and enter areas such as renewable energy, digital infrastructure, healthcare, telecommunications and clean technology, officials said recently.

The last India-Africa Forum Summit took place in 2015 here, in the national capital. Since then, the world has witnessed many changes. The COVID-19 outbreak and the Russia-Ukraine conflict have created much vulnerability in the current supply chain and energy security systems. In this scenario, organising a revived version of the Summit is not just about carrying out regular diplomatic activities. According to experts, the 4th IAFS is an essential step toward realising their common vision of leadership.

KEY POINTS

- Bilateral trade crossing USD 85 billion and investments nearing USD 80 billion indicate that the relationship has acquired substantial economic depth
- The last India-Africa Forum Summit took place in New Delhi in 2015

In addition, African countries are looking for new kinds of engagements that do not involve the same extractive model as before. The Indian government continually stated that the strategy followed by India was one of building capacities, developing skills, and empowering people, rather than extracting resources. Also, India's growing diplomatic footprint in Africa reflects this long-term strategic recalibration. The opening of 17 new diplomatic missions since 2018 signals an acknowledgement that sustained political engagement requires institutional presence on the ground. It also demonstrates that New Delhi understands the importance of engaging not only major African powers such as Nigeria and South Africa, but also smaller and emerging economies across the continent.

The recent crisis in West Asia also exposes India's long standing weakness. India is heavily dependent on West Asia, which is always a volatile region, for its essential energy supplies. Located between Oman and Iran - the Strait of Hormuz is a narrow yet vital checkpoint. Nearly half of India's crude oil imports and nearly 70 per cent of its LNG transit through this narrow passage, according to the centre. Any disruption here would quickly result in higher energy prices or inflationary pressures.

Not only energy, the region is also key for fertilisers, industrial inputs and remittances.

For this reason, there is India's effort to synchronise their developmental dreams in line with that of Africa's developmental dreams in the Agenda 2063 framework. The coincidence of the developmental dreams in terms of "Viksit Bharat 2047" and those of Africa enable India to project its collaboration with Africa as one involving transformational development, not one-sided charity.

Yet, the contemporary India-Africa connection goes well beyond economic matters - security collaboration has emerged as an integral component of the relationship as the situation deteriorates in certain regions of Africa as well as the Indian Ocean region. Maritime security, counter-terrorism, and defence training and peacekeeping all form an important part of the evolving relationship.

Officials mentioned that with over 5,000 Indian peacekeepers serving in various United Nations' missions around the African continent. On the other hand, the instability in countries such as Sudan, Libya, and the Red Sea as well as piracy in maritime areas are a reflection of the security challenges involved in deepening relations with Africa.

Yet another crucial dimension that arises out of these talks involves mobility and migration. With increasing numbers of Indian professionals, workers, and students settling in African countries, issues such as legal protection, anti-immigration feelings, and institutional mechanisms for migration are gaining importance. In this context, the recognition by the officials that discussions are on to enhance travel, connectivity, and mobility are most welcome.

It was pointed out that India's aspirations in Africa would finally be measured by results and not promises alone. Problems associated with delays in execution, procedures for the Lines of Credit, poor infrastructure, and inadequate private sector funding continue to pose serious problems.

However, indications by the Indian government that reform initiatives are already taking place within the context of the policy governing development projects and Lines of Credit have been very promising.

Punjab CM hails 'anti-sacrilege' law

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Monday offered prayers at Gurdwara Jyotisar Sahib and expressed gratitude for getting the opportunity to enact the Jaagat Jot Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Act 2026, asserting that the law would ensure strict punishment for incidents of beadbi and act as a strong deterrent against sacrilege.

Joining the Sangat during the bhog of Sri Akhand Path Sahib, Mann said the legislation had brought immense relief and satisfaction to the Sikh community. He said people across Punjab were organising thanksgiving paths following the enactment of the law, which seeks to preserve the sanctity of Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji.

"The Almighty has bestowed upon me the service to serve humanity by enacting a strict law against beadbi," Mann said, adding that no one would now dare to indulge in such acts.

The chief minister reiterated that the AAP government remained fully committed to Sikh values and public sentiments and promised strict action against anyone involved in sacrilegious incidents.

Mann also launched a sharp attack on the BJP-led Centre, alleging that key decisions in the country were being influenced by the White House. Referring to recent developments linked to India-US relations, he claimed that India's sovereignty was being compromised and criticised the Centre's economic policies, particularly foreign investment in the defence sector.

On the Enforcement Directorate raids in Punjab, Mann accused the Union government of misusing central agencies to intimidate opposition leaders. He asserted that Punjabis would never bow before pressure tactics aimed at suppressing democratic voices.

mp

EDITORIAL

FROM QUEUES TO FLOW?

For decades, the Indian highway experience has been defined by contradiction. The country built wider roads, launched ambitious expressways, and celebrated infrastructure as a symbol of progress, yet everyday highway travel remained frustratingly inefficient. Anyone who has driven long distances in India knows the ritual well — endless queues at toll plazas, vehicles abruptly slowing down, FASTag scanners malfunctioning, impatient honking, and precious minutes wasted in congestion. Even after electronic toll collection through FASTag, motorists still had to crawl through toll booths instead of enjoying uninterrupted travel. Now, with the launch of India's first multi-lane free flow (MLFF) barrierless tolling system at the Choryasi Toll Plaza on Gujarat's Surat-Bharuch stretch of NH-48, the government is attempting to fundamentally change how Indian highways function.

The MLFF system replaces physical toll barriers with overhead digital gantries equipped with Automatic Number Plate Recognition (ANPR), FASTag-linked RFID readers, as well as RADAR and LiDAR systems. Vehicles no longer need to stop or slow down for payment. The system identifies vehicles, deducts toll charges automatically, and issues electronic notices to defaulters. The principle is straightforward — highways should function like highways, not bottlenecks interrupted every few kilometres. This shift matters because India's economy increasingly depends on efficient highways for freight movement, logistics networks, industrial supply chains, and inter-city commerce. Delays at toll plazas may seem minor individually, but collectively they impose enormous costs through fuel wastage, delayed transportation, congestion, and lost productivity.

The advantages of a genuinely barrierless system could therefore be significant. India's logistics sector has long struggled with inefficiencies that raise transport costs and weaken competitiveness. Trucks spend hours trapped at toll points across long routes, burning fuel while standing still. Such inefficiencies eventually affect businesses and consumers alike. MLFF seeks to address this structural problem through uninterrupted traffic flow. Faster movement means lower fuel consumption, reduced travel time, and greater efficiency for commercial transport. There are environmental benefits as well. Toll plazas become concentrated pollution zones because thousands of vehicles repeatedly brake, idle, and accelerate throughout the day. Removing stoppages can reduce emissions and improve air quality around highways. The Choryasi Toll Plaza is an important testing ground because it ranks among India's top toll collection centres and handles heavy traffic volumes daily. If the system succeeds there, it could become a model for nationwide expansion.

Yet India's technological transitions rarely unfold without complications, and the success of MLFF will depend more on execution than ambition. The system relies heavily on accurate number plate recognition, stable digital networks, updated databases, and seamless FASTag integration. In Indian conditions, these assumptions are not always reliable. Vehicle number plates are often damaged, poorly standardised, obscured by dirt, or deliberately manipulated. FASTag users already complain about duplicate deductions and scanner failures under the current system. If similar glitches emerge under MLFF, public frustration could escalate quickly. A wrongful deduction or inaccurate penalty notice may appear minor in isolation, but repeated errors can rapidly erode trust in automated governance systems. The proposed electronic grievance redressal mechanism will therefore be crucial. Citizens are more willing to accept technology-driven systems when corrections are transparent, fast, and accessible.

There is also a deeper transformation unfolding beneath the surface — the shift from visible administration to invisible digital enforcement. Traditional toll plazas were physical spaces where transactions occurred face-to-face. MLFF removes that human layer and replaces it with algorithmic oversight. Every vehicle movement becomes digitally recorded and linked to centralised databases. In many ways, this reflects a broader trend in Indian governance, where digital systems increasingly regulate everyday life. Such systems undoubtedly improve efficiency and reduce leakages, but they also expand the state's technological visibility over citizens. India's public debate often celebrates digitisation without equally discussing privacy safeguards, data security, or accountability. As automated systems become embedded in public infrastructure, those concerns can no longer remain secondary.

Still, India cannot remain trapped in outdated infrastructure models. The scale of the country's highway network and the growing demands of freight mobility require smarter systems. The real challenge is not whether India should adopt technologies like MLFF, but whether it can implement them thoughtfully. If executed properly, barrierless tolling could reduce congestion, lower pollution, improve transport efficiency, and modernise highway travel. But if technological errors, opaque enforcement, and weak grievance mechanisms dominate the experience, the reform risks becoming another ambitious idea undermined by poor implementation.

TALKING SHOP

RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER IS A VETERAN JOURNALIST AND COMMUNICATIONS SPECIALIST

Nearly 100,000 schools have quietly disappeared across the nation over the last decade. Yet, not one of the recent assembly elections mentioned India's vanishing classrooms. What has happened to our social consciousness?

Locked Classrooms

In the recent state polls, India's political blue boys thundered over identity and ideology. The breakdown of India's school system didn't make it to any podium

Somewhere in rural India, a child walked to school last week and found the gates locked. There was no prior warning, no public consultation, no community outrage dramatic enough to trend online. Just a dusty board announcing that the school had been 'merged', 'rationalised' or 'consolidated' into another institution a few kilometres away. The blackboards were gone. The classrooms emptied. The morning assembly dissolved into bureaucratic legalese. And life moved on. The rural-folk trudged to their fields, this time children in tow.

In a democracy as loud as India's, how has the closure of thousands of schools not become an electoral issue?

India just concluded assembly elections in five states, finely studded with the usual democratic spectacle. There were accusations and counter-allegations, celebrity roadshows and dynasty debates, communal rhetoric and promises of jobs, subsidies and nationalism delivered at deafening volume. Television studios transformed into war rooms of political prophecy. Yet, amid all the shouting, a national crisis barely found mention – the inexorable disappearance of India's schools.

This silence should terrify us. Because countries do not decline only when economies collapse or governments fail. They also decay quietly when classrooms disappear, teachers vanish and a society stops treating education as a national imperative. Data presented in Parliament shows that more than 93,000 schools have shut down over the past decade, with government schools accounting for a majority. In the last five years, over 19,000 government schools disappeared from the system.

This number should trigger national alarm. Instead, it barely disturbed the news cycle. No one paid any political price. No mass electoral revolt was witnessed. Constituencies voted along familiar faultlines while classrooms vanished behind them. Schools disappeared. Governments barely noticed. Voters appeared more animated about roads, caste, celebrity candidates or religious rhetoric than children without a school. The question, therefore, is not whether India has an education crisis. It is whether education is a societal priority at all.

Silent Collapse

The official speak for the closures is deceptively reasonable. Schools are being 'merged' due to falling enrolment, teacher shortages and to improve administrative efficiency. Some institutions report only single-digit student numbers. Others exist only on paper. In states such as Himachal Pradesh, hundreds of schools have been shut down because enrolment dropped to zero.

On paper, rationalisation sounds efficient. On the ground, it can be brutal. For a child in a remote village, the closure of a local school does not merely mean shifting buildings. It can mean walking several extra kilometres every day. It can mean unsafe commutes for girls. It can mean parents quietly withdrawing children altogether. For poorer families, particularly in rural India, proximity is not convenience. It is survival.

The tragedy is compounded by our public education system, which was fragile long before the closures began. Teacher shortages remain chronic. Infrastructure gaps persist. Learning outcomes continue to alarm. NITI Aayog says enrolment in government schools has fallen sharply over two decades, dropping below 50 per cent.

Parents are abandoning government schools long before governments abandon them. Those who can afford private schooling are embracing it; those who cannot are negotiating decay. The result is vicious. Falling enrolment justifies closures. Closures weaken access. Weak access pushes families toward private alternatives or educational disengagement. Communities slowly lose faith in public education. Yet, politically, the issue is anaesthetised. This is strange, for India can erupt over examination leaks, reservation disputes and language wars. Is there muteness on this issue because the victims are dispersed, poor and politically fragmented?

Global Warning

India is not alone in confronting educational strain. Worldwide, public education systems are under pressure from demographic shifts, privatisation, migration and post-pandemic disruptions. In Europe and East Asia, falling birth rates have forced school consolidation. In the United States, learning losses after COVID-19 are haunting classrooms. Many developing nations struggle with teacher shortages and widening educational inequality.

But India's challenge is particularly dangerous because of scale. It is still a young nation aspiring to become a global economic powerhouse. It speaks of demographic dividends, artificial intelligence, manufacturing ambition and 'Viksit Bharat'. Such aspirations sound hollow when even basic schooling becomes uncertain. Remember, schools are more than centres of literacy. They are social infrastructure. They provide nutrition through midday meals, safety, routine and are often the only institutional support for vulnerable children.

When a school shuts down, the ecosystem standing on its foundations collapses with it. Our education debate mimics a conversation obsessed with elite aspiration, neglecting foundational collapse. Policymakers speak loudly of global universities, coding skills and digital classrooms. Just some distance away, thousands of children struggle for access to even a functioning primary school. The contrast is dystopian. One India debates AI. The other worries whether the village school will still be standing next year.

History books overflow with warnings. Nations that neglect mass education eventually pay through inequality, social fragmentation and weakened economies. East Asian economies invested heavily in schooling long before they became tech giants. Scandinavia protected public education fiercely even amid welfare reforms. China's rise was built partly on state investment in literacy and basic schooling. But India is attempting great-power ambition atop eroding educational foundations. That is not a strategy, but wishful thinking doomed to fail.

Electoral Silence

What makes this crisis disturbing is the absence of a political fallout. In a democracy as loud as India's, it is strange that the closure of schools not become a burning issue. The answer may lie in the fragmentation of public anxiety. Voters are confronting inflation, unemployment, healthcare pressures and economic crises, all simultaneously. Education, despite its long-term importance, loses out to immediate survival concerns. Political parties understand this arithmetic. And short-term emotion defeats long-term investment.

Another trigger is that education rarely produces instant political rewards. A highway is visible. A cash transfer is immediate. A religious slogan is emotionally explosive. But the benefits of preserving public schooling emerge slowly, years later. Democracies driven by electoral immediacy struggle with such timelines.

In India, public education is becoming a residual service for those too poor to escape it; thus, it is politically expendable. The disappearance of schools is not merely about education. It is a warning about the society we are becoming; with opportunity privatised, inequality institutionalised and public systems allowed to wither as long as the middle-class continues to purchase alternatives. Such a model rarely ends well.

Very Last Bell

The haunting aspect of school closure is not merely the numbers, but the normalisation. No country can afford to remain comfortable watching classrooms disappear. Yet, we are treating closures as administrative footnotes, not civilizational alarms. And the national conversation around their disappearance is astonishingly muted.

Perhaps we assume technology will compensate. Perhaps policymakers feel consolidation means efficiency. Perhaps voters have simply stopped expecting the government to educate their children adequately. But nations do not become 'developed' by building highways, stock markets and data centres. They do so by protecting the ordinary classroom, especially the forgotten rural one where opportunity first enters a child's life.

There is time to reverse course. Governments can stop viewing school closures through the lens of enrolment efficiency and begin measuring social consequences. Rural access must be non-negotiable. Teacher vacancies must be filled. Public education must be about nation-building, not fiscal inconvenience. Most important, voters must rediscover education as a political demand. At the end of the day, the danger is not that schools are shutting down. It is that India has begun treating their disappearance as normal.

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Views expressed are personal

SECURITY WATCH

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Authorities are probing extremist recruitment, possible institutional infiltration, sensitive information leaks, and radical outreach through digital and overseas networks

Ominous Signs of Terror?

Alleged extremist infiltration within Bangladesh Air Force has triggered nationwide security concerns, reviving fears over militancy, institutional vulnerability and radical networks

According to an unconfirmed report appearing in a section of the media in Bangladesh, an Air Force (BAF) Warrant Officer who went missing from a Chattogram base has been traced to a Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) hideout, triggering a deep internal probe into suspected extremist links within the service. This has been informally confirmed by multiple sources in security and intelligence quarters. They also disclosed that more than 20 people have been detained in the last week, including 12 combatant BAF members — two officers, several Warrant Officers and airmen — and over 10 non-combatants, including an Imam of a BAF base mosque. The development is disturbing and has led to coordinated probes follow-up across BAF installations, with officials examining whether a regular recruitment network operated inside the force for months, and whether sensitive information may have been exposed or Bangladeshi recruits sent abroad to join extremist activities.

If extremist infiltration into the BAF is confirmed, Bangladesh and South Asia will face serious new security challenges

What triggered the inquiry was the two-month absence without leave of the Warrant Officer posted at the BAF base in Chattogram, Zahurul Haque. He was later identified and arrested at a TTP hideout. However, when contacted, Inter-Services Public Relations (ISPR) Director Sami Ud Dowla Chowdhury told *The Times of Bangladesh* that they would not offer any comments for confirmation. TTP's linkages to Bangladesh came to the surface last year after reports claimed that at least four Bangladeshis were killed by Pakistani forces. Investigators revealed that the questioning of the Warrant Officer also exposed claims that several Bangladeshis had travelled to Pakistan, joined the TTP, and actively participated in the fighting.

Preliminary findings point to possible links involving personnel across squadrons, including a unit in Cox's Bazar, though the scope of involvement remains under enquiry. Investigators are examining claims by the arrested Warrant Officer that TTP-linked recruitment efforts had been underway for months and may have involved more BAF personnel. At least six Warrant Officers previously linked to the case are suspected to have left Bangladesh for destinations including Turkey, Pakistan, New Zealand and Portugal, complicating the probe and widening its global dimension.

Apart from the disclosures made by the Warrant Officer, the authorities claim to have seized electronic devices belonging to the absconding airmen, leading to the detention of many persons. Surveillance has been intensified after indications emerged that efforts were afoot to establish a possible training facility in the Ukhia area of Cox's Bazar. Security agencies, meanwhile, are assessing risk factors, including the potential leakage of sensitive military information. Officials described the situation as one of serious internal security concerns. However, they cautioned that the investigation is ongoing and that individual culpability is yet to be established.

In a related recent development, the Police Headquarters in Dhaka issued a nationwide alert about possible militant attacks on key installations, including the Jatiya Sangsad Bhaban (Parliament), public places such as Shahbagh intersection, places of worship, entertainment centres, police and army establishments, as well as armouries. Despite contradictory statements later made by Home Minister Salahuddin Ahmed and Dr Zahed Ur Rahman, the Prime Minister's Adviser on Information and Broadcasting, on the existence of militancy in Bangladesh, the alert underscores that violent extremism has not yet disappeared; it has only changed form, language and platform.

A report by The Daily Star, based on court filings and intelligence findings, warns that police detected communications between alleged Neo-Jama'atul Mujahideen Bangladesh (JMB) members; and that a 16-year-old boy from Habiganj Sadar had been in regular contact with two dismissed army personnel. After the boy's arrest earlier this month, the Counter Terrorism and Transnational Crime (CTTC) unit seized his phone and found incriminating materials that investigators believe indicate links with Neo-JMB, as well as his presence at a secret meeting at Zia Udyan. The documents describe him as an "IS-ideology follower/Neo-JMB member." Officials claim the group used online platforms and pseudonyms, with the boy allegedly even receiving bomb-making training. If true, this is highly disturbing.

Experts say counterterrorism should not mean panic, media trial or collective suspicion of religious groups. After the recent terrorism alert, a CTTC joint commissioner was right in saying there is no reason to panic. But calm is not the same as denial. Earlier assurances from the interim government sit uneasily alongside the recent warnings, suggesting that security concerns may have been overlooked. It may be recalled that in July 2025, then Home Adviser Jahangir Alam Chowdhury had said there was no militancy in Bangladesh. Around the same period, then DMP Commissioner Sheikh Md Sazzat Ali reportedly dismissed militancy as a current problem. They were perhaps far removed from reality.

It is important to assert that TTP, or the Pakistani Taliban, is not an ordinary political or religious group. The UN Security Council sanctions narrative identifies it as being associated with al-Qaeda. The Global Terrorism Index 2026 sees TTP as one of the four deadliest terrorist organisations globally in 2025, saying it was the only one among the four to record an increase in terrorism-related deaths. This is the organisation some Bangladeshi extremists are believed to be trying to join. Bangladesh has lived through this terror-linked development before.

According to Asif Bin Ali, a well-known columnist in The Daily Star and a geopolitical analyst and doctoral fellow at Georgia State University in the US, there is still a mistake Bangladesh must not repeat. Denial is dangerous, but politicised counterterrorism is dangerous too. For years, governments have used the language of terrorism to discredit political opponents. Social media and the public sphere also need to be reviewed. In recent years, pro-al-Qaeda, pro-ISIS, pro-Taliban and Neo-JMB-style narratives have become more visible on social media and public forums. Not every conservative religious view amounts to extremism and the state must never criminalise belief. But it must draw a clear line between religious expression and ideological preparation for violence. Bin Ali's thoughts perhaps merit attention.

Bangladesh's security and intelligence agencies need resources, training, coordination and public support. But they also need reform and accountability. The nation has reduced the visible threat of terrorism over the years, but low visibility does not mean the absence of threat. Extremism often becomes quiet, reorganises, enters new platforms and waits for political confusion. To address the extremism-related national security threat, the answer is neither blind support for security agencies nor cynical dismissal of every warning.

If the penetration of extremists into the BAF is proved correct following investigations, it will pose a new challenge to Bangladesh as well as the South Asian region. Prime Minister Tarique Rahman must take up this threat as a priority and nip it in the bud before it assumes serious proportions.

Views expressed are personal

DC's marvellous chase

Miller, Axar keep DC alive with record chase; PBKS lose four in row

Delhi Capitals' captain Axar Patel plays a shot against Punjab Kings PTI

DHARAMSALA: David Miller and captain Axar Patel engineered a record run chase for Delhi Capitals with their counter attacking knocks as the visitors upstaged Punjab Kings by three wickets to stay alive in the Indian Premier League here on Monday.

Aggressive knocks from Miller (51 off 28) and skipper Axar Patel (56 off 30) allowed Delhi Capitals to gun down 211 in 19 overs for the highest chase at the HPCA Stadium.

Priyansh Arya hit half a dozen sixes in his whirlwind 33-ball 56 before Delhi Capitals pacers tweaked their lengths to limit Punjab Kings to 210 for five. Having remained unbeaten in the first half of the tournament, Punjab Kings have now lost four in a row and need at least two wins from their remaining three games to make the play offs.

Barring Arshdeep Singh, the bowlers let the team down with their wayward display.

However, the home team's bowlers did the job in the powerplay. Punjab Kings struck thrice for the first time in the powerplay, leaving Delhi Capitals reeling at 47 for three in the first six overs.

Arshdeep Singh, who has been rather expensive this season, returned impressive figures of two for 21 in four overs.

It was Yash Thakur who provided the first breakthrough by castling Abishek Porel with a ball that seamed back in from length to knock out the middle stump. KL Rahul was caught at fine leg after mistiming a whip off Arshdeep. The young Sahil Parakh played a few impressive strokes in his brief stay before being crammed up for space by Arshdeep to be caught at short third man.

It became 74 for four with the run out of Tristan Stubbs extending the struggles of DC batters. However, Miller (51 off 28) and Axar (56 off 30) brought life back into the game with their counterattacking 64-run stand off 34 balls.

Eventually, Ashutosh Sharma (24) and Madav Tiwari (18) came up with timely cameos to keep DC alive in the competition.

DC, struggling to stay alive in the tournament, opted to field in the first game of the season at the scenic venue here after making five changes to their side. The ball generally flies off the bat in the high altitude of Dharamsala and that was very much evident in the first over of the game from Mitchell Starc, who proved rather expensive on the night.

Priyansh took the veteran Australian pacer to the cleaners in the over that went for 22 runs. His onslaught included a six square of the wicket on either side.

The southpaw not only dispatched Starc for a first ball six, he also meted out the same treatment to the wily Lungi Ngidi and Mukesh Kumar.

Starc understandably went full to search for the swing but DC pacers realised that bowling full was not the way go on this surface after conceding 51 runs from the first thee overs. AGENCIES

Sunrisers and GT to slug it out

Ahmedabad: As the IPL enters its decisive final phase, second-placed Sunrisers Hyderabad and third-ranked Gujarat Titans prepare for a critical showdown here on Tuesday, which could prove to be pivotal in shaping the playoffs race.

The Shubman Gill-led GT appear slightly better placed after recovering from a slow start to the season with a string of crucial wins, including a commanding 77-run victory over Rajasthan Royals, which lifted them to third on the points table. With the top three sides -- RCB, SRH and GT -- all locked on 14 points, net run rate could become a decisive factor in the race for the playoffs, making it imperative for SRH to improve theirs in front of their home crowd. SRH have found their rhythm at the right time, with 33-run win over Punjab Kings. AGENCIES

'WON'T TAKE SANYAAS FROM WRESTLING'

Round 2 begins as Vinesh defies WFI ban, pulls up at the venue

Vinesh Phogat arrives for the tournament in UP's Gonda PTI

> What do you expect me to do? Shall I take sanyaas and stay away? Accept defeat? So that their conspiracy against me succeeds?
>
> Vinesh Phogat

GONDA: A defiant Vinesh Phogat's attempt to compete in the National Open Ranking tournament after replying to WFI's show-cause notice was on Monday categorically rejected by the federation, triggering a dramatic fresh confrontation, with the decorated wrestler calling it a "pre-planned conspiracy" to stop her comeback.

Vinesh arrived at the venue and claimed she was eligible to return to competition despite the federation declaring her ineligible till June 26, 2026 due to the mandatory six-month notice period for athletes returning from retirement under anti-doping rules. But the federation refused to accept her documents.

"What do you expect me to do? Shall i take sanyaas and stay away? Accept defeat? So that their conspiracy against me succeeds?" Vinesh told reporters after meeting WFI President Sanjay Singh. "They are not allowing me. They want to see me tried and retired. All I am asking is a fair chance to compete but they are insisting that first I reply to their notice."

Vinesh said she had not violated any rule of NADA or WADA, and had come out clean in dope tests.

"If I had violated any rule, NADA or WADA would have given me a show-cause notice or banned me. Even after that, I underwent doping tests and came clean. I have always been clean in sports. ITA conveyed to me that I am eligible to compete from January 1, 2026. They can directly say they don't want me to play or step on the mat. Instead, they are troubling me so much that I get tired and leave myself," she said.

Calling the show-cause notice a "pre-planned conspiracy", she alleged that the timing was deliberately chosen to leave her with little legal recourse before the tournament. "I got the notice on Friday night. Saturday I was reducing weight and doing paperwork. They knew exactly when to send the notice, when courts would be closed and when filing would become difficult. This is all preplanned," she alleged.

The WFI maintained that she could not compete in the event till the completion of disciplinary proceedings conducted by a panel.

Sanjay Singh said: "She only recently said that she plans to compete in Gonda. Before that we did not know when she plans to come back. Only when she registered she came under WFI. So we acted accordingly."

"She did not reply when I asked why she competed in two weight divisions. She blamed it on ad-hoc panel. Once she replies and it is a satisfactory reply, we will think about our next move," he said. AGENCIES

'WE WERE NOT CONSISTENT ENOUGH'

MI's season fell apart due to 'inconsistency'

> We've had our opportunities. We were not good enough
>
> Mahela Jayawardene, Mumbai Indians' coach

RAIPUR: Head coach Mahela Jayawardene admitted that Mumbai Indians were simply "not good enough" this season after a heartbreaking two-wicket defeat to Royal Challengers Bengaluru ended their IPL playoff hopes here.

The defeat, MI's eighth in 11 matches, also exposed the inconsistency that plagued the five-time champions throughout the campaign.

"Yeah, I mean, the season, it's disappointing," Jayawardene said after the match.

"We've had our opportunities. We were not good enough. We were not consistent enough with the ball, with the bat, and that showed the margins."

MI appeared in control at various stages of the contest but failed to close out the game after handing the final over to rookie all-rounder Raj Angad Bawa, who was bowling for the first time in his four-year IPL career.

Defending a narrow total, Bawa began with a wide and a no-ball before dismissing Romario Shepherd, only to concede another wide and then a decisive six to Bhuvneshwar Kumar as RCB sealed victory off the last ball.

"All our bowlers were finished (with their quota of overs) at that time, we didn't have anyone left, any experienced bowler," Jayawardene explained.

"We had couple of spinners; one was Raghu Sharma who hadn't bowled. The other option probably would have been Allah Ghazanfar. I think Suryakumar backed Raj. Raj is a decent bowler. We know what he can do in practice, executing yorkers, the wide stuff and all that." Jayawardene, however, sympathised with the youngster for faltering under pressure. AGENCIES

Watched by grieving coach, Barca retain La Liga title by beating Real

Mourning glory

Barcelona's Ronald Araujo lifts the trophy as the team celebrates AP

BARCELONA: Watched by their grieving coach, Barcelona won their second straight Spanish league title and 29th overall with a comfortable 2-0 win over Real Madrid at Camp Nou on Sunday, adding to their rivals' troubled season.

Goals by Marcus Rashford in the ninth minute and Ferran Torres in the 18th gave Barcelona the victory and an insurmountable 14-point advantage over its fierce rival with three rounds remaining in La Liga.

Barcelona coach Hansi Flick was in the dugout for Sunday's clasico following the death of his father, which Barcelona announced hours before kickoff.

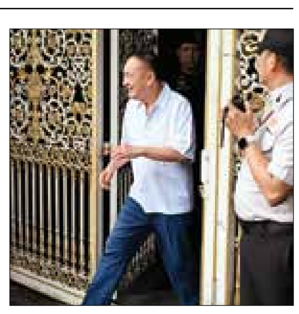
Players from both teams wore black armbands and there was a moment of silence before kickoff. A draw would also have been enough for the Catalan club to seal their third league title in four seasons. Madrid, who remain the most successful club in the league with 36 trophies, is ending a second consecutive season without a major title.

Sunday's defeat at Barcelona capped an embarrassing week for Madrid, marked by altercations between players in training that led the club to fine Federico Valverde and Aurélien Tchouaméni 500,000 euros

"I will never forget this day. It was a tough day for me. It starts with this (news that) my father passed away, but here, my team is fantastic," Flick said. AGENCIES

World

Thailand's former PM Thaksin freed from jail



Thailand's former Prime Minister Thaksin Shinawatra

BANGKOK: Thailand's former Prime Minister Thaksin Shinawatra, whose 21st-century political odyssey sharply divided Thai society for decades, was released from a Bangkok prison on Monday after serving eight months of a one-year sentence for a corruption-related charge.

A crowd of about 300 supporters and political allies gathered outside the Klong Prem Central Prison to greet the 76-year-old billionaire populist.

Thaksin was a telecommunications magnate who founded his own political party in 1998 and served as prime minister from 2001 until a military coup ousted him in 2006 while he was abroad. AGENCIES

TRUMP'S CHINA VISIT SET TO TEST TIES

Trump-Xi summit comes with high stakes for Taiwan

US President Donald Trump with Chinese counterpart Xi Jinping

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump, in his return to the White House, has demonstrated greater ambivalence toward Taiwan, an approach that is raising questions ahead of this week's summit with Chinese President Xi Jinping about whether the US leader could be open to dialling back support for the island democracy that Beijing views as its breakaway province.

Trump in December authorized $11 billion arms package for Taiwan - the largest weapons sale ever to the island - but has not yet moved forward with delivery and even acknowledged that he's discussed the sale with Xi. He's groused that Taiwan "stole" America's semiconductor business and called on Taiwan to pay the US for protection.

All the while, Trump has, with the threat of hefty tariffs, prodded Taipei to agree to massive investments in US semiconductor manufacturing and to purchase billions of dollars' worth of US liquefied natural gas and crude oil.

His rhetoric is fuelling speculation in Beijing, Taipei and Washington about America's commitment to help the island defend itself and whether Trump could be persuaded to cede ground on the longstanding US posture toward the island.

> TAIWAN'S BACKERS ARE CONCERNED THAT TAIPEI WILL BE ON THE MENU WHEN BOTH LEADERS SIT DOWN FOR TALKS

Taiwan's backers are concerned that Taipei will be "on the menu" when Trump and Xi sit down for talks, said retired US Navy Rear Adm. Mark Montgomery. "I do worry that we have a transactional president and a transactional opportunity could arise, and then we would have a challenge," said Montgomery. AGENCIES

Rubio says US policy is unchanged

The Chinese have signalled they intend to make Taiwan a central part of the talks between Xi and Trump this week. Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi raised Taiwan during a call with Secretary of State Marco Rubio to prepare for the trip, and urged the United States to "make the right choices" about its policies toward the island in order to safeguard "stability" between the two nations, according to a statement by the Chinese Foreign Ministry.

EU sanctions Israeli settlers, Hamas leaders

Representational Image

BRUSSELS: The European Union reached a unanimous political agreement Monday to issue new sanctions on Hamas leaders and the Israeli settler movement, top European diplomats said, after years of deadlock and growing popular pressure sparked by the carnage in Gaza.

EU's foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas said in a social media post after a meeting in Brussels on Monday of the 27-nation bloc's foreign ministers that extremism and violence should carry consequences. The group failed to endorse even stronger measures pushed by some European governments and did not immediately release details of the new measures, but French Foreign Minister Jean-Noël Barrot said the ministers had decided to sanction Hamas leaders and both leaders and organisations in the Israeli settler movement in the West Bank. "The European Union is sanctioning today the main Israeli organizations guilty of supporting the extremist and violent colonization of the West Bank, as well as their leaders. These most serious and intolerable acts must cease without delay," he said in a post Monday on social media.

"It is sanctioning the main leaders of Hamas, responsible for the worst antisemitic massacre in our history since the Shoah during which 51 French people lost their lives, a terrorist movement that must imperatively be disarmed and excluded from any participation in the future of Palestine," Barrot said. AGENCIES

Man charged in White House press gala attack pleads not guilty

WASHINGTON: A man accused of storming the White House Correspondents' Association dinner while armed with guns and knives pleaded not guilty on Monday to charges that he attempted to kill President Donald Trump and fired a shotgun at a Secret Service officer who tried to stop the attack.

Cole Tomas Allen was handcuffed and shackled and wearing an orange jail uniform when he appeared in federal court for his arraignment.

Allen didn't speak during the brief hearing. Allen's lawyers are asking US District Judge Trevor McFadden to disqualify at least two top Justice Department officials from direct involvement in prosecuting him. AGENCIES

Iran ceasefire at its weakest: Trump

The US, Iran have been negotiating a deal to end the hostilities for good

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump on Monday said the ceasefire with Iran was at its "weakest" and on "massive life support", a day after he rejected Tehran's proposal to end the months-long war as "totally unacceptable".

"It is at its weakest… After reading that piece of garbage they sent us… It's on life support, massive life support," Trump told reporters at the Oval Office in response to a question on the ceasefire with Iran in the wake of the rejection of the peace proposal.

"They think that I'll get tired of this, or I'll get bored, or I'll have some pressure, but there's no pressure, there's no pressure at all. We're going to have a complete victory," Trump said.

Trump received the Iranian proposal on Sunday and hopes that it could lead to a breakthrough to end the war with Iran that began on February 28, blocking the key sea route for global oil supplies, leading to fuel shortages in several countries.

"I have just read the response from Iran's so-called Representatives.' I don't like it," he wrote on his Truth Social platform on Sunday, calling it "totally unacceptable".

The US and Israel's war on Iran started on February 28, and attacks have been paused since April 8, when the warring sides agreed to a ceasefire.

The US and Iran have been negotiating a deal to end the hostilities for good, but peace has been elusive so far.

The US has been insisting that Iran give a clear commitment to end its uranium enrichment programme in exchange for the lifting of sanctions and release of billions in frozen Iranian funds. AGENCIES

Adani calls for India to build own AI and power infra on home soil

'Adani said the assumptions underpinning decades of globalisation were being dismantled amid rising geopolitical fragmentation'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Billionaire Gautam Adani said on Monday that energy security and digital infrastructure would define geopolitical power in the coming decades, as he called on India to build sovereign capabilities across the artificial intelligence value chain.

Addressing the Confederation of Indian Industry's Annual Business Summit 2026, the chairman of the Adani Group said the assumptions underpinning decades of globalisation were being dismantled amid rising geopolitical fragmentation. "The world that is emerging is not flat. It is fractured and contested," Adani said. "Semiconductors have become instruments of statecraft. Data is being treated as a national resource. Clouds are being weaponised. And Artificial Intelligence is being built behind the protective walls of data centres."

Referring to recent geopolitical conflicts and attacks on infrastructure, Adani said "energy security and digital security are now the twin pillars of national power." "The country that controls its energy will power its industrial future. The country that controls its compute will power its intelligence future. And the country that controls both will shape the century ahead," he said.

Adani Group chairman Gautam Adani

Adani said 'energy security and digital security are now the twin pillars of national power'

Highlights

- 'The country that controls its energy will power its industrial future. The country that controls its compute will power its intelligence future'
- And the country that controls both will shape the century, the Adani Group chief said
- 'India should treat AI not merely as software, but as strategic infra spanning energy, data centres, chips, networks, compute and talent'

Adani said India should treat AI not merely as software, but as strategic infrastructure spanning energy, data centres, chips, networks, compute and talent. "India must not rent the infrastructure of its intelligence future. India must build it, power it and own it on its own soil," he said.

The billionaire industrialist said India's scale of domestic demand across manufacturing, mobility, logistics and digital services positioned it uniquely to build large-scale AI and energy infrastructure with demand "already embedded into the economy". He noted that India had crossed 500 gigawatts of installed power capacity and said the country's future AI economy would require massive investment in energy and compute ecosystems.

"India must build AI not as a force that removes opportunity, but as one that expands productivity, creates jobs, empowers entrepreneurs and gives Indians the tools to compete globally," Adani said.

He reiterated his ports-to-energy conglomerate's previously announced $100 billion commitment towards energy transition and digital infrastructure, including the 30-GW renewable energy project at Khavda in Gujarat and partnerships with Google and Microsoft in India's data centre and sovereign compute ecosystem.

Reflecting on the group's growth, Adani said he had spent decades building "from ports where there were only marshlands to power projects in regions that knew only darkness". "The future does not arrive. It is built," he said.

He added that the next "freedom struggle" would be fought "in our grids, our data centres, our factories, our classrooms, our laboratories and our minds," and that freedom in the AI era would mean "the capability to power ourselves, compute for ourselves and dream for ourselves".

The Adani Group chairman said the US and China had both recognised that "energy and intelligence are now inseparable" and had made them strategic national priorities. He said India's growth trajectory positioned it uniquely to build large-scale domestic energy and AI infrastructure, citing rising electricity demand, rapid urbanisation and digital adoption.

"As of March 2026, India has crossed 500 GW of installed power capacity," he said, adding that India was on track to quadruple capacity to 2,000 GW by 2047. India's AI-driven data centre capacity, projected at 5 GW by 2030, could rise to nearly 75 GW by 2047, he said warning that the country needed to prepare immediately for the surge in compute demand.

"AI is not just software. AI is infrastructure. AI is energy. AI is cooling. AI is chips. AI is networks. AI is data. AI is talent. AI is governance," Adani said.

He rejected concerns that artificial intelligence would primarily destroy jobs, saying India should use AI to "expand productivity, create new jobs, empower small businesses and give Indians the tools to compete with the best."

Drawing parallels with India's digital payments revolution, Adani said the launch of UPI had enabled the emergence of companies such as Flipkart, Paytm, Ola, Swiggy, Meesho, Zepto, and PhonePe by making millions of Indians digitally visible and financially connected.

"AI will do the same but at a far greater scale," he said.

Railways utilised 98% capex by Feb-End, says Ashwini Vaishnaw

'In the last financial year, the entire capex was spent practically by the 1st week of March itself,' Vaishnaw said

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Indian Railways utilised 98 per cent of its budget for FY26, reflecting the pace of execution of projects, and in the days to come, trains will dominate flights on several upcoming corridors across the country, Union Minister for Railways Ashwini Vaishnaw said on Monday.

"In the last financial year, the entire capex was spent practically by the 1st week of March itself. Practically by the last week of February, it was like 98 points some percentage. Then we had to, in a sense, stop that because we have to complete the entire year," Vaishnaw said.

He said 49,000 kilometres of railway tracks across the country have been electrified, which is more than the entire network of Germany, and 36,000 kilometres of new tracks have been added, which is about six times the size of Switzerland in the Indian railway network.

The minister said that on many of these routes, travel time will be significantly reduced, and people will prefer trains to air travel.

Vaishnaw said the government is working on new corridors from Mumbai to Pune, where travel time will come down to just 28 minutes, Pune to Hyderabad will be one hour and 55 minutes, and Hyderabad to Bengaluru will be around 2 hours.

Union Minister for Railways Ashwini Vaishnaw

He said 49,000 kilometres of railway tracks across the country have been electrified, which is more than the entire network of Germany

"So nobody will fly. These sectors will be out for airlines. I'm reminding right away for those who want to invest in airlines. These sectors will be 99 per cent dominated by railways," Vaishnaw said.

He said Bengaluru to Chennai will become two cities combined into one city, with travel time between them reduced to 78 minutes.

"Delhi to Varanasi will be 3 hours and 50 minutes. Delhi to Lucknow will be significantly lesser, just about 2 hours," Vaishnaw added.

Talking about the efficient and adequate transportation of coal through freight operations, Vaishnaw said that while coal shortages at power plants were once a major problem, today these plants have abundant coal supplies.

"We have 54 million tonnes of coal stored at power plants even in the month of May," Vaishnaw said, adding that the normal stock level is 15–16 million tons.

He stated that the last financial year was the safest in the 150-year history of Indian Railways, as accidents had been reduced by 90 per cent.

He informed that the Dedicated Freight Corridor (DFC), whose last section up to JNPT Port was under construction, was completed on April 5, 2026. Its operationalisation has increased train frequency as well as reduced the travel time of freight trains.

He also expressed great satisfaction while announcing that India has started exporting the most complex part of a train — the propulsion system — to countries such as Germany, Italy, Switzerland, Poland, and the US.

BSE launches F&O contracts on Focused IT Index

NEW DELHI: BSE on Monday launched futures and options (F&O) contracts on the BSE Focused IT Index, becoming the only stock exchange in India to offer derivatives linked to an IT sector benchmark.

The BSE Focused IT Index comprises 14 major Indian technology companies and is aimed at providing investors with a focused benchmark for the IT sector.

The launch, coinciding with National Technology Day, is intended to help investors hedge, trade and manage risks related to the IT industry, which is influenced by global economic trends, currency fluctuations and rapid technological changes.

On the first trading day, 172 members participated in the product, generating a turnover of Rs 148 crore.

According to BSE, the IT sector accounts for around 6 per cent of the total market capitalisation of listed companies on the exchange and nearly 6 per cent of foreign portfolio investments in the Indian equity market. More than 250 IT firms are listed on the exchange.

The exchange also said 17 passive investment products in India are currently benchmarked to IT indices, reflecting the sector's growing importance among investors. The contracts will be cash-settled and available in three serial monthly expiries. AGENCIES

'Fertilisers stock comfortable to meet requirement of Kharif season'

NEW DELHI: The Centre on Monday asserted that the stocks of fertilisers in the country is "comfortable" and it will ensure adequate supply of soil nutrients during the upcoming Kharif (summer-sown) season.

In an inter-ministerial briefing on recent developments in West Asia, Aparna S Sharma, Additional Secretary in the Department of Fertilizers, said the maximum retail price (MRP) of major fertilisers have remained constant.

She also emphasised that India's fertilizer security remains comfortable and well managed.

"On behalf of the Department of fertilizer, this is to inform that as on date for the season of kharif 2026, based on the fertilizer requirement that has been assessed by the Department of Agriculture, the stock is more than 51 per cent...," Sharma said.

She noted that the stock position is significantly higher than the usual level, which is 33 per cent of the demand.

The Department of Agriculture has assessed the fertiliser requirement for kharif 2026 at 390.54 lakh tonnes.

"So the fertilizer stock is comfortable, and the MRP of major fertilizer remains very much the same," Sharma said.

After the crisis period, she said the domestic production has been 76.78 lakh tonnes while imports at 19.94 lakh tonnes.

"So a total of 97 lakh metric tonnes of fertilizer has been added to the availability after the crisis situation," the additional secretary informed.

Elaborating, Sharma said India has secured 7 lakh tonnes of NPK complexes from global sources.

"Further 12 lakh tonnes of DAP (di-ammonium phosphate) and 4 lakh tonnes of triple super phosphate and 3 lakh tonnes of ammonium sulfate, have been secured for the country. This will ensure adequate availability for the peak season that will start in about 15-20 days time," she said.

Sharma said an empowered group of secretaries is reviewing the situation on a weekly basis. PTI

Indian industry needs to leverage & utilise free trade agreements, says Commerce Secy

NEW DELHI: The Indian industry needs to leverage and utilise the free trade agreements (FTAs) that India is finalising, as they provide huge opportunities for both trade and investments, Commerce Secretary Rajesh Agrawal said on Monday.

The secretary said that the track record of the country fully utilising and leveraging FTAs is "not great".

He also said that the country's industrial policy should complement its trade policy, as trade is also a function of how India invests and produces.

"...FTA utilization is something we are questioned again and again. What is the benefit that FTAs are actually leading to?," he said here while addressing a session on free trade agreements.

India has implemented trade pacts with a number of countries and groupings including Singapore, Japan, Korea and Asean.

Agrawal said these pacts have led to increase in bilateral trade, but India's exports have grown at a slower pace than imports.

Talking about the trade pacts with Mauritius, the UAE, Australia, the EU, UK, EFTA, New Zealand and Oman, he said these are "modern" agreements and have gone beyond tariffs.

He added that all the stakeholders including the industry and the government need to take steps to make these pacts useful for the country.

Dissemination of information and capacity building is important for increasing utilisation of these FTAs, he said adding "If you are able to do that, I think we will create the right vibrancy, right ecosystem at least to work towards leveraging these FTAs".

He asked the industry to include these pacts in their long-term business strategy.

"Indian companies will need to look at more and more opportunities to becoming a part of global value chains," he said.

Further he said that the new FTAs of India are with developed economies, which are complementary in nature, and which can bring investments into India.

"We are expanding beyond tariffs, talking about services in greater manner, talking about harmonisation of regulations because at the end of these FTAs, we want to provide a very predictable trade, tariff and regulatory environment to our investors and industry," he said.

These pacts, he said, would not just help increase trade but also create a right foundation for getting the right investments both domestic and FDI.

"...Because trade is also a function of how we invest and how we produce. If you do not invest enough, you do not produce enough and trade will not take place," he added.

He said these agreements provide a framework and a pathway, but would remain mere papers if they are not leveraged effectively.

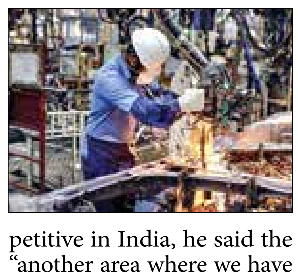
"The potential that it creates, needs to be leveraged and that leveraging will happen by stakeholders of both sides," he said. PTI

Government identifying 100 products to boost domestic manufacturing, says DPIIT Secretary

NEW DELHI: The government is working with industry to identify about 100 products — including those from the auto sector — that are either not produced or manufactured inadequately in India, as part of efforts to boost domestic production, according to a top official.

Secretary in the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), Amardeep Singh Bhatia, said a set of "unique and interesting" products has already been identified, including items from the auto sector such as axles and motorcycle components.

Talking about a series of steps taken by government to make manufacturing competitive in India, he said the "another area where we have been working is to bring in another 100 products which are either not getting manufactured in India as of now or which are not sufficiently being manufactured at the moment".



The objective is to expand manufacturing for both domestic and global markets.

"We are working closely with the industry (on that)," he said adding "lot of things not getting manufactured in India and we have the capability...may be some gaps in technology, which can be bridged.

He was speaking at a CII conference. Bhatia also said that the department will so launch 'Made in India Brand Scheme'.

"We have had a pilot run with the steel sector, and it has been quite encouraging," he said, adding the scheme will provide a brand with a logo.

A domestic company, he said, will be able to use that Made in India brand to not only indicate the value addition but also assure quality.

He said that the industry will be consulted to finalise the sectors.

Talking about artificial intelligence, he said it is moving "very" fast and is affecting manufacturing through greater productivity and more innovation.

"We should be ready for that...world over, this change has been felt," Bhatia said, adding that the uncertain geopolitical uncertainties too have affected supply chains.

The secretary also urged the domestic industry to invest in India on a long-term basis. "I encourage all of you to take advantage of opportunities being created to do more investments," he said. He added that the free trade agreements (FTAs) finalised by India would provide huge opportunities for Indian businesses. PTI

Govt revises BOT guidelines, allows big funds to bid for highway projects

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MoRTH) has allowed big funds and large investors to bid for build-operate-transfer (BOT) projects after some projects failed to attract private investments due to concerns over contract terms. Earlier, big funds were allowed to bid only for toll, operate and transfer (TOT) projects.

The ministry has allowed sovereign wealth funds, infrastructure funds and pension funds, and private equity to bid for BOT projects under the public-private-partnership (PPP) model. In a modified request for proposal (RFP) document, MoRTH has relaxed norms for investments in such projects.

The ministry came out with the modified framework after four highway projects worth Rs 22,000 crore failed to attract bids from private companies under the BOT model due to concerns over contract terms.

National Highways are developed under different modes of execution, including BOT or toll, BOT (annuity), Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC), InvIT and Hybrid Annuity (HAM) model.

Under the BOT mode, the government provides a concession period of 20-30 years to finance, build and operate highway projects.

According to the modified RFP document, the bidder may be a natural person, private entity, government-owned entity, Alternative Investment Fund (AIF), Foreign Investment Fund or any combination of them with a formal intent to enter into a Joint Bidding Agreement to form a consortium.

As per the document, institutional investors will be assessed on financial strength, while construction-related technical qualifications can be met through concessionaires or engineering partners hired after the project award. PTI

PSU fuel retailers staring at Q1 losses large enough to wipe out profitability for full fiscal

Despite a 50% rise in input crude oil prices, petrol & diesel continue to be priced at two-year-old rate of Rs 94.77 a litre and Rs 87.67 per litre respectively

NEW DELHI: India's state-run fuel retailers are staring at first-quarter losses large enough to wipe out profitability for the full fiscal year, as soaring crude prices and a government-led freeze on pump prices squeeze marketing margins, Agencies according to a top government source.

Since the war broke out in the Middle East 10 weeks ago, state-owned oil marketing companies (OMCs) have ensured uninterrupted supplies of petrol, diesel and cooking gas LPG at rates that are way below cost, unlike many global energy systems that imposed rationing or passed through steep price increases.

This has resulted in the three OMCs - Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) - running record high under-recoveries (the difference between cost and retail selling price), the source, who wished not to be named, said.

The combined under-recovery on petrol, diesel and cooking gas LPG is Rs 1,000 crore to Rs 1,200 crore daily, he said.

Despite a 50 per cent surge in input crude oil prices, petrol and diesel continue to be priced at a two-year-old rate of Rs 94.77 a litre and Rs 87.67 per litre respectively. Domestic cooking gas LPG prices were raised in March by Rs 60 per cylinder, but they are still way lower than the actual cost.

"At current oil prices, the losses in the current quarter (April-June) will wipe out the company's entire year's profit of about Rs 76,000 crore," he said, adding that after considering losses in March - the first month of the crisis - the cumulative losses come to about Rs 1 lakh crore. The oil companies are currently losing Rs 14 per litre on petrol, Rs 42 a litre on diesel and Rs 674 a litre on cooking gas LPG.

CLOSER LOOK

- LPG prices were raised in March by Rs 60 per cylinder, but they are still way lower than the actual cost
- The oil cos are currently losing Rs 14/litre on petrol, Rs 42/litre on diesel & Rs 674 a litre on cooking gas LPG
- For 10 weeks, the OMCs have managed to insulate the Indian market but now the cost is visible, the source said

Commenting on rising losses faced by oil marketing companies, Prashant Vashisht, Senior Vice President & Co-Group Head, Corporate Ratings, ICRA Ltd, said, "The oil marketing companies are incurring substantial losses on the sale of auto fuels and domestic LPG owing to high international crude oil and product prices.

"ICRA estimates that at crude prices of USD 120-125 per barrel, and considering the past 10-year average crack spreads for auto fuels, oil marketing companies incur losses of around Rs 1,000 crore per day on the sale of auto fuels and domestic LPG. This level of losses is unsustainable and would need to be addressed if elevated crude oil and product prices persist over an extended period."

The revenues that OMCs earn from selling fuel are the only source that is used by them to buy crude oil (raw material), build infrastructure to process it into fuel and lay a network to take the product to consumers.

For 10 weeks, the OMCs have managed to insulate the Indian market but now the cost is visible, the source said, adding they may have to borrow more to meet the working capital requirement (buying of crude oil).

"If elevated crude prices persist for an extended period, OMCs may require higher working capital borrowings and calibrated reprioritisation of some capex timelines," he said. "However, strategic investments in refining expansion, energy security infrastructure, ethanol blending, biofuels, and transition fuels continue to remain national priorities and are expected to proceed with Government support."

While countries from Japan to the United Kingdom have raised petrol and diesel prices by up to 30 per cent since the start of the West Asia conflict, fuel prices in India continue at two-year-old levels.

This despite the war disrupting India's import of 40 per cent of crude oil (raw material for making petrol and diesel), 90 per cent cooking gas LPG and 65 per cent natural gas (used to generate electricity, make fertiliser, turned into CNG and piped to household kitchens for cooking). PTI

Sensex crashes over 1,300 pts amid rising crude oil prices

In three sessions since Thursday, Nifty dropped over 2 per cent or 515 points, while Sensex has fallen by nearly 1,950 points or 2.5 per cent

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Stock markets fell for the third day running on Monday, with the benchmark Sensex tumbling 1,313 points amid rising crude oil prices after the US and Iran failed to reach a peace deal to end the war in West Asia.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 1,312.91 points, or 1.70 per cent, to settle at 76,015.28.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 360.30 points or 1.49 per cent to end at 23,815.85. In three sessions since Thursday, Nifty dropped over 2 per cent or 515 points, while Sensex has fallen by nearly 1,950 points or 2.5 per cent.

Titan, a leading jewellery and fashion accessories company, was the biggest loser among Sensex companies, dropping by nearly 7 per cent. InterGlobe Aviation, SBI, Bharti Airtel, Eternal and Reliance Industries were among the major laggards.

Sun Pharma, Hindustan Unilever, Adani Ports, Kotak Mahindra Bank, Axis Bank and ICICI Bank were the winners.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, traded 2.23 per cent higher at $103.5 per barrel.

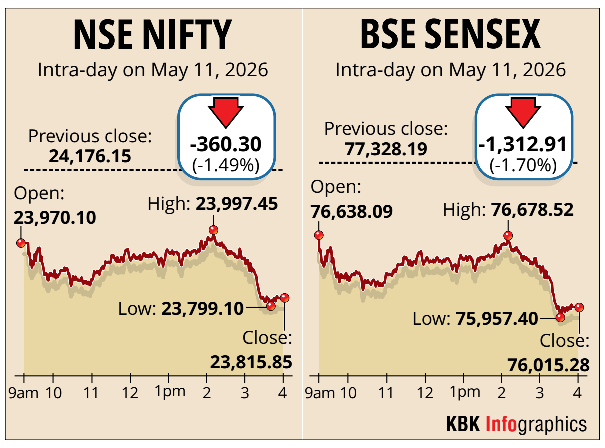
Jewellery stocks faced heavy selling pressure, with Sky Gold and Senco Gold falling over 12 per cent intra-day before closing lower by over 6 per cent. Senco Gold closed 7.8 per cent lower after falling 10 per cent in the day trade.

The BSE MidCap Select index tanked 1.09 per cent and BSE SmallCap Select index declined 0.44 per cent.

Sectorally, Consumer Durables index tumbled 3.76 per cent, Realty (2.74 per cent), MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt (2.60 per cent), BSE PSU Bank (2.28 per cent), Consumer Discretionary (2.14 per cent) and Power (2.13 per cent). BSE Healthcare and Hospitals were the winners. A total of 2,892 stocks declined, while 1,457 advanced and 189 remained unchanged on the BSE.

FIIs offloaded equities worth Rs 4,110.60 crore on Friday, according to exchange data.

On Friday, the Sensex tanked 516.33 points or 0.66 per cent to settle at 77,328.19. The Nifty dropped 150.50 points or 0.62 per cent to end at 24,176.15.



Sectorally, Consumer Durables index tumbled 3.76%, Realty (2.74%), MidSmall Pvt Banks Quality Tilt (2.60%), BSE PSU Bank (2.28%), Consumer Discretionary (2.14%) and Power (2.13%)

Highlights

- Titan, InterGlobe Aviation, SBI, Bharti Airtel, Eternal & Reliance Industries were among the major laggards
- Sun Pharma, Hindustan Unilever, Adani Ports, Kotak Mahindra Bank, Axis Bank and ICICI Bank were the winners
- BSE MidCap Select index tanked 1.09% & BSE SmallCap Select index fell 0.44%
- A total of 2,892 stocks declined, while 1,457 advanced and 189 remained unchanged on the BSE

Rupee tanks 79 paise to 95.28 against $

MUMBAI: The rupee tanked 79 paise to settle at its record low of 95.28 against the US dollar on Monday after US President Donald Trump rejected Iran's response to the West Asia peace proposal, following which crude oil prices surged rapidly.

A strengthening US dollar and steep foreign capital outflows further pressured the local unit, according to forex traders.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 94.97 and traded in the range of 94.87-95.34.

It eventually settled at its record low of 95.28, down 79 paise from its previous close.

India's forex stocks fell $7.794 bn to $690.693 bn during the week ended May 1, the RBI said on Friday. In previous week ended April 24, the overall stocks fell $4.82 bn to $698.487 bn. PTI

India to grow 6.6% in FY27, needs package on BoP front: SBI report

Meanwhile, SBI Research said the Q4 FY26 real GDP growth is expected to be closer to 7.2 per cent

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India's economy is projected to grow at 6.6 per cent in 2026-27 fiscal while a comprehensive package is required on the Balance of Payments (BoP) front amid rupee depreciation and higher oil price, an SBI Research report said on Monday.

The report said the rupee, which has weakened much in the recent period "through clouds on external macros, as also unabated speculative forces" needs structural changes on BoP front, stream lining the guard rails of import substitution, export competitiveness, integration in global value chain.

The rupee has breached the 95-mark against the US dollar that has strengthened due to rising global uncertainties

The rupee has breached the 95-mark against the US dollar that has strengthened due to rising global uncertainties, triggered by the West Asia conflict.

"There is now a felt need to put in place a comprehensive package to address Balance of Payments (BoP)," SBI Research said and made a strong case for diaspora bonds.

With the country's macro fundamental getting distorted as Brent crude prices hover above $100, and transport and insurance costs spiking, there is a need to put in place measures that alleviate BoP position, it said.

"...if USD/INR rate (is) at Rs 95, then the economy size will fall to $4.04 trillion and the dream to be $5 trillion economy may be achieved in the year FY30," the report said.

It also cautioned that the rapid, though infrequently incessant episodes of slide in rupee, coupled with extreme pangs of volatility, may dampen the confidence of investors.

According to the report, a resurgent Indian Diaspora Bond has to be calibrated suitably across corpus, yield, tenor and tax-friendly treatment for investors upon maturity to ensure it does not end in a catch-22 situation.

SBI Research's suggestion also comes against the backdrop of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, on Sunday, highlighting the need to save foreign exchange due to the West Asia crisis as well as judicious use of fuel, postpone purchase of gold and foreign travel for one year.

India is dependent on imports to meet more than 80 per cent of its energy needs.

Meanwhile, SBI Research said the Q4 FY26 real GDP growth is expected to be closer to 7.2 per cent and "now casted full year 2026-27 GDP growth rate of 6.6 per cent. FY26 GDP growth is likely to be at 7.5 per cent".

The RBI in the first Monetary Policy Committee meeting of the fiscal projected the GDP growth for FY27 at 6.9 per cent.

Key Points

- '...if USD/INR rate (is) at Rs 95, then the economy size will fall to $4.04 trillion & dream to be $5 trillion economy may be achieved in FY30'
- It also cautioned that the rapid, though infrequently incessant episodes of slide in rupee, may dampen the confidence of investors
- The RBI in the first MPC meeting of the fiscal projected GDP growth for FY27 at 6.9%

Gold declines ₹600 to ₹1.55 lakh/10 grams

NEW DELHI: Gold prices fell Rs 600 to Rs 1.55 lakh per 10 grams in the national capital on Monday after US President Donald Trump rejected Tehran's response to Washington's peace proposal, raising fears of renewed conflict in West Asia and pushing crude oil rates higher.

Additional pressure came from Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal to defer non-essential gold purchases for a year in an effort to protect the country's external balances.

According to the All India Sarafa Association, gold of 99.9 per cent purity decreased by Rs 600 to Rs 1,55,300 per 10 grams from Friday's closing level of Rs 1,55,900 per 10 grams.

However, silver prices climbed by Rs 3,700, or 1.42 per cent, to Rs 2,65,000 per kilogram. The white metal had settled at Rs 2,61,300 per kg in the previous session.

Gaurav Garg, Research Analyst at Lemonn Markets Desk, said silver saw a slight uptick, benefiting from steady retail demand amid the approaching wedding season.

In the global markets, spot gold fell more than 1 per cent to $4,661.68 per ounce, and silver was also trading marginally lower at $80.28 per ounce. PTI

We expect US team to visit India for next round of trade talks: Official

NEW DELHI: India expects the US team to visit the country for the next round of trade talks, though no dates have been finalised yet, an official said on Monday. The Indian side visited Washington, DC, in April for an in-person round of meetings with their US counterparts to finalise the details of the interim agreement and take forward the negotiations under the broader bilateral trade agreement (BTA).

"Now we expect the US team to visit India next for trade talks. No dates have been decided," the official said.

After the April meet, both sides have agreed to stay engaged to sustain the momentum ahead for the trade talks.

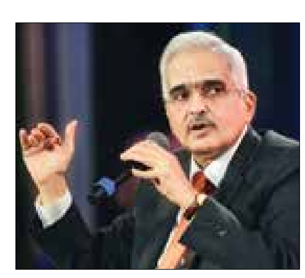
Last month, officials of the two sides discussed several areas, such as market access, non-tariff measures, technical barriers to trade, customs and trade facilitation, investment promotion, economic security alignment and digital trade.

India and the US issued a joint statement on February 7 finalising a framework for an interim trade agreement regarding reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade. The framework reaffirmed the countries' commitment to the broader India-US BTA negotiations.

India's outbound shipments to the US grew marginally by 0.92 per cent to $87.3 billion during the last fiscal year, while imports increased 15.95 per cent to $52.9 billion. The trade surplus declined to $34.4 billion in FY26 from $40.89 billion in FY25. PTI

India Inc should reorient business to be future-resilient, diversify supply chain: Das

NEW DELHI: Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister Shaktikanta Das on Monday urged Indian industry to strategically reorient businesses from concentrated supply chains towards diversification and long-term resilience amid rising geopolitical uncertainties and supply chain disruptions.



Principal Secretary to Prime Minister Shaktikanta Das

Addressing the Confederation of Indian Industry Annual Business Summit, Das said overdependence on a narrow set of markets and single-source supply chains increases vulnerability during global slowdowns, especially for exporters.

"Market diversification would spread the risks, stabilise revenue streams and allow firms to tap into new growth corridors and demand patterns," he said.

Das noted that businesses globally had long focused on efficiency through just-in-time and single-source supply chains, but geopolitical fragmentation and conflicts have exposed risks in such models.

"In this context, resilience maximisation is increasingly replacing cost minimisation as a priority for corporates and businesses," he said, adding that operational strategies need to shift "from concentration to diversification and from short-term efficiency to long-term resilience".

He said India has taken several measures to shield the economy from global uncertainties, including investments in renewable energy, infrastructure expansion and free trade agreements with various nations.

According to Das, India's push towards alternative energy and renewable investments has strengthened the country's ability to deal with disruptions arising from the conflict in West Asia.

Highlighting infrastructure development, he said rising central government capital expenditure has driven rapid expansion of infrastructure projects across the country.

"Amidst global geopolitical and geoeconomic tensions, India offers a striking counter-narrative," Das said.

He also outlined seven priorities for businesses — building organisational resilience, strengthening balance sheets, creating new supply chains, reskilling manpower, diversifying markets, investing for future readiness and increasing research and development spending.

Das said India continues to pursue reforms and strategic self-reliance in sectors such as critical minerals, shipbuilding, cotton productivity and artificial intelligence. AGENCIES

Equity MFs inflow dips 5% to ₹38,440 cr in April

NEW DELHI: Equity-oriented mutual fund schemes recorded net inflows of Rs 38,440 crore in April, a decline of 5 per cent from Rs 40,450 crore in March, amid geopolitical tensions in the Middle East and fluctuating crude oil prices, according to data released by Association of Mutual Funds in India on Monday.

Monthly SIP contributions also declined to Rs 31,115 crore in April from Rs 32,087 crore in March.

Despite the moderation, equity inflows remained higher than the Rs 25,978 crore recorded in February and marked the 62nd consecutive month of positive flows.

Overall, the mutual fund industry witnessed a net infusion of Rs 3.22 lakh crore in April after an outflow of Rs 2.4 lakh crore in March, supported by a sharp rebound in debt-oriented schemes that attracted Rs 2.5 lakh crore. In March, debt funds had seen an outflow of Rs 2.95 lakh crore.

The industry's assets under management rose 11 per cent to Rs 81.92 lakh crore at the end of April from Rs 73.73 lakh crore in March.

Venkat Chalasani, Chief Executive of Amfi, said the growth in assets was driven by "strong positive flows across segments and market to market gains witnessed during the month".

Within the equity category, Flexi Cap funds led inflows with Rs 10,148 crore. Small-cap funds attracted Rs 6,885 crore, while mid-cap funds received Rs 6,551 crore.

Large-cap funds registered inflows of Rs 2,525 crore.

However, Dividend Yield and Equity Linked Savings Scheme (ELSS) funds saw marginal outflows due to profit booking and portfolio rebalancing.

Debt-oriented schemes saw strong inflows into liquid, overnight and short-duration funds. Liquid funds led the recovery with inflows of Rs 165,105 crore, followed by overnight funds at Rs 31,420 crore and money market funds at Rs 20,643 crore.

"This reflects the typical post year-end redeployment of liquidity after March outflows," Umesh Sharma, CIO- Debt at The Wealth Company said.

However, long-duration and gilt categories continued to see outflows, indicating persistent caution on interest rate risk, while corporate bond funds recovered with moderate inflows, he added.

"Against the backdrop of a challenging global environment, Indian mutual fund investors have shown commendable resilience. Equity flows have held up well, reflecting the growing maturity of our investor base and the deepening awareness about the merits of systematic investing. While markets will always have to contend with geopolitical developments, the data suggests that long-term financial goals are increasingly guiding investment decisions over short-term noise," Navneet Munot, MD & CEO of HDFC AMC said.

Gold exchange-traded funds recorded inflows of Rs 3,040 crore in April compared with Rs 2,266 crore in March. MPOST

Essar Energy Transition sees £1.9 bn annual GVA to UK economy by 2035

STANLOW (UK): Essar Energy Transition on Monday released its maiden In Country Value Overview Report, highlighting its contribution to the UK economy, energy security and industrial decarbonisation.

The independent report by FGE NexantECA projected that the company's operations would generate £1.9 billion in annual Gross Value Added (GVA) to the UK economy by 2035 and support nearly 10,000 long-term jobs.

As one of only four remaining UK refineries, Stanlow currently supplies 18 per cent of the country's road transport fuel and 12.5 per cent of total UK jet fuel demand, including 25 per cent of jet fuel demand from airports outside Heathrow. It also supports 50 per cent of the UK's inorganic chemicals industry.

In 2025, the company collected £4.2 billion in VAT and fuel duty, representing 0.7 per cent of all VAT receipts and 13 per cent of fuel duty receipts. It also supported 4,917 direct, indirect and induced jobs and spent £471 million across its supply chain, including £426 million in the UK.

Deepak Maheshwari, CEO of Essar Energy Transition Fuels, said the company is "a cornerstone of national energy security" and supports nearly 5,000 jobs across the UK economy.

Prashant Ruia, Chairman of Essar Energy Transition, said, "Our £4.3 billion investment pipeline is a massive growth opportunity for Britain. By 2035, these projects will generate nearly £2 billion in annual value to the UK and support 10,000 jobs. We are proving the UK can lead the global energy transition without sacrificing its industrial heritage."

Ruth Herbert, Chief Business Development Officer and MD of Essar Energy Transition, said decarbonisation need not lead to deindustrialisation if backed by clear policies and timely incentives. She urged the government to ensure fair carbon taxes and support decarbonisation infrastructure in North West England. MPOST

Canara Bank Q4 standalone net profit down 10% to ₹4,506 crore

NEW DELHI: State-owned Canara Bank on Monday reported a 10 per cent year-on-year decline in standalone net profit to Rs 4,506 crore during the March quarter.

The bank had posted a net profit of Rs 5,002.66 crore in the same quarter a year ago.

Also, the bank's total income dropped 1.85 per cent for the January-March period of 2026 declined to Rs 36,662 crore from Rs 37,353 crore in the same period of the preceding fiscal year, Canara Bank said in a regulatory filing.

Net interest income, or core income, grew nearly 4 per cent to Rs 9,808 crore in the quarter under review from Rs 9,442 crore.

On the asset quality front, the bank's gross non-performing assets (NPAs) or bad loans improved to 1.84 per cent of the gross advances at the end of March 2026, as against 2.94 per cent at the end of March 2025.

In value terms, the gross NPAs were worth Rs 22,740 crore, down from Rs 31,530 crore. Similarly, net NPAs also improved to 0.43 per cent (Rs 5,209 crore) during the quarter under review, down from 0.7 per cent per cent (Rs 7,353 crore).

The bank recommended a dividend of Rs 4.20 per equity share for 2025-26, subject to approval by shareholders at the ensuing Annual General Meeting.

For the full-year FY26, the bank reported a 12.7 per cent year-on-year surge in profit to Rs 19,187 crore. Its total income increased to Rs 1,53,204 crore in FY26 from Rs 1,42,208 crore in FY25. PTI

Urban Unemployment dips to 6.6% in March qtr: Survey

Rural unemployment edged up to 4.3% in the March quarter from 4.0% in the previous quarter

NEW DELHI: Urban unemployment rate declined marginally to 6.6 per cent in the January-March 2026 quarter from 6.7 per cent in October-December 2025, according to the latest Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) released by the National Statistics Office on Monday.

The survey covered 5,61,822 persons aged 15 years and above and marked the fourth quarterly PLFS bulletin providing estimates for both rural and urban areas.

While urban unemployment showed a declining trend, rural unemployment edged up to 4.3 per cent in the March quarter from 4.0 per cent in the previous quarter.

In rural areas, the share of regular wage/salaried employees rose to 15.5 per cent during January-March 2026 from 14.8 per cent in the previous quarter. However, the share of self-employed persons declined to 62.5 per cent from 63.2 per cent.

CLOSER LOOK

- In rural areas, the share of regular wage/salaried employees rose to 15.5% during January-March 2026
- However, the share of self-employed persons declined to 62.5 per cent from 63.2 per cent
- Share of rural workers engaged in agriculture sector declined to 55.8% from 58.5% in the previous quarter

The survey said the rural workforce continued to be largely dependent on agriculture, though the share of workers engaged in the sector declined to 55.8 per cent from 58.5 per cent in the previous quarter. Employment in the tertiary sector increased to 21.7 per cent from 20.6 per cent, while the secondary sector, including mining and quarrying, rose to 22.6 per cent from 20.9 per cent.

In urban areas, the sectoral distribution of workers remained broadly stable with employment concentrated in the tertiary sector.

The Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR) remained steady at 55.5 per cent during Q4 FY26 compared to 55.8 per cent in previous quarter. Rural LFPR stood at 58.2 per cent and urban LFPR at 50.2 per cent. Female LFPR remained broadly stable at 34.7 per cent against 34.9 per cent in the previous quarter.

The Worker Population Ratio stood at 52.8 per cent compared to 53.1 per cent earlier. On average, 57.4 crore persons were employed during the quarter, including 40.2 crore men and 17.2 crore women. AGENCIES

PUBLIC NOTICE

We, **Shri Raj Kumar Aneja S/o Sh. Sagan Lal Aneja and Smt. Uma Aneja**, R/o House No. 2 M-26, BP, NIT, Faridabad, Haryana, hereby declare that our son, Rohit Aneja Date of Birth: 25-12-1997, is no longer under our control. Our son, Rohit Aneja, engages in quarrels and disputes with us, subjects us to vile verbal abuse, and issues threats to kill us, as well as threats to take his own life. Therefore, having severed all ties with him, we hereby disinherit our son, Rohit Aneja, from our residential property House No. 2M-26, BP, NIT, Faridabad) and from all our movable and immovable assets. In the future, should anyone engage in financial transactions with him, they shall be solely responsible for the consequences; neither we nor our family shall bear any liability in this regard.

Applicants : Raj Kumar Aneja, Uma Aneja

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CHANGE OF NAME

I, Somwati W/o Lal Singh R/o H.No.E-42/94 Sonia Camp, Jhilmil Industrial Area, Gt Road, Shahdara Delhi-110095. That my father name wrongly mentioned in my pan card is Lal Chand my father correct name is Sukh Vasi. That my father correct name is Sukh Vasi for all future purpose.

I Sana Qutbi D/O Syed Shijauddin Qutbi R/o House No. 1055, G/F-1, Palam Apartment, Ward No.7, Mehrauli, New Delhi-110030. declare that name of my mother and my father have been wrongly written as Simmi Begum and Syed Shijauddin in my birth certificate and my school certificate documents. The actual name of my mother and my father are Shamim Qutbi and Syed Shijauddin Qutbi.

I, Amit Kumar S/o Shri Satish Kumar R/o House No C-4,. Plot No. 102, Shanti Kunj Main, Near Surat Garden, Sec-D-4, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi-110070, do hereby That my Daughter name is Kiana Arora But my daughter name mentioned in her birth certificate written as Kiana Arora alias Kiana. That I further declare Kiana Arora and Kiana Arora alias Kiana is the one and same child name.

I, Anil Singhal, S/o Sh. Bhajan Lal Singhal, R/o Ah-14, 2nd Floor, Shalimar Bagh, Delhi-110088, Aadhar Card No. (7484-6856-6637), do hereby declare That in my Passport bearing Passport No. [P4319347], my name has been wrongly mentioned as Anil Kumar Singhal.That both the names, namely Anil Kumar Singhal and Anil Singhal, refer to one and the same person i.e. myself.

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

CORRIGENDUM

Corrigendum Notice No. W.584/E-Tendering/21,22-DHN-26-27, Dhanbad, dt. 08.05.2026

(1) It is further to notify that, in the E-Tender No.21-DHN-2026-27 dtd. 28.04.2026, **Tender value** should be read as **₹6,59,99,105.52** instead of ₹6,60,36,751.43.

(2) It is further to notify that, in the E-Tender No.22-DHN-2026-27 dtd. 28.04.2026, **Tender value** should be read as **₹4,83,96,028.14** instead of ₹4,83,96,028/-

All other details, term and condition exists in the e-tender notice No. 21-DHN-2026-27 and 22-DHN-2026-27 dtd. 28.04.2026 will remain unchanged and unaltered.

Divisional Railway Manager (Engg.)
ECR/Dhanbad

PR/0204/DHN/Engg./C/26-27/24

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Sumeet @ Abhishek S/o** Gote Ram @ Sote Ram, **R/o** H.No. 475, Post. Office Wali Gali, Bawana, Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 18176/2023, U/S 411 IPC, PS Bawana, Outer North Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sumeet @ Abhishek** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sumeet @ Abhishek** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Sumeet @ Abhishek** the said accused of **FIR No. 18176/2023, U/S 411 IPC, PS Bawana, Outer North Distt., Delhi,** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.07.2026.**

By Order
Ms. Bharti Beniwal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05,
Court No.-114, 1st Floor, North Distt.,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/6157/ON/2026
(Court Matter)

OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER
MINOR IRRIGATION DIVISION, CHATRA

e-Procurement Tender Notice
Two Envelope system

Tender Reference No. WRD/MID/CHATRA/F2-02/2026-27 Date:- 11.05.2026

1	Date of publication of Tender on website	20.05.2026 at 2.00 pm
2	Last date/Time for submission of Bids	04.06.2026 at 5.00 pm
3	Date of opening of e-Tender	06.06.2026 at 12.00 pm
4	Name & address of office Inviting tender	Executive Engineer, Minor Irrigation Division, Chatra.
5	Contact no. of Procurement officer	06541-223672
6	E-mail of e-procurement Officer	eemidchat-cemr-jhr@nic.in
7	Helpline number of e-Procurement cell	06541-223672
8	Last Date of submission of Bid online/Time for receipt of bids	04.06.2026 Up to 5.00 pm

Sl No.	Name of Scheme	Estimated Cost (in Lakh)	Time of Completion
1	Renovation of Barki Tal Aahar, Block- Mayurhand, Dist.- Chatra.	18267600.00	11 Months

Note :- 1. Only e-Tenders will be accepted.
2. Tender Fee and EMD will be received through online mode only, Bidders can use internet banking facility for faster processing of Tender Fee and EMD. Alternatively, Bidders can use NEFT/RTGS challan generated for the tender from https://jharkhandtenders.gov.in portal.
3. Refund will only be issued to originated bank account used for the payment of Tender Fee and EMD, so, Bidder are advised NOT to close Bank Accounts used for online payment /(NEFT/RTGS) of tender fee and EMD.
4. No Hard copy/Physical copy is required to be submitted for tender opening/valuation, However, Department may ask original document for verification before award of contract.
5. Estimated value may change.
6. Further details can be seen on website https://jharkhandtenders.gov.in.

Executive Engineer,
Minor Irrigation Division, Chatra.

PR 379462 Minor Irrigation(26-27)#D

GOVERNMENT OF JAMMU AND KASHMIR
OFFICE OF THE EXECUTIVE ENGINEER, IRRIGATION & FLOOD CONTROL DIVISION SOPORE

Corrigendum

Reference:-This office e-nit No:-02 of 2026-27 Dated:- 24/04/2026 bearing endorsement No: 541-59 Dated:- 24/04/2026

In compliance to the directions of Worthy District Superintending Engineer Hyd Circle Baramulla/ Bandipora H.Q Sopore given vide No. 8785424/2026/SE/Hydraulic Baramulla/710-12 Dt: 11-05-2026, the following corrigendum is hereby issued in case of bid capacity.

Clause	To Be Read As	Instead of
Bid Capacity	The bidder should possess the bidding capacity as calculated by the specified formula. The formula used is: **Available bid capacity = A x M x N -B, where** **A** = Maximum value of engineering (Civil/ Electrical/Mechanical as relevant to work being procured) works executed in any one year during the last five years updated at the current price level), onsidering the Completed as well as works in progress. **M** = Multiplier Factor (2.5) **N** = Number of years prescribed for ompletion of the work in question. (period up to 6 months to be taken as half-year (0.5) and more than 6 months as one year (1.0) **B** = Value (updated at the current price level) of the existing commitments and ongoing works to be completed in the next 'N' years, as per FIN 4 in section 4.	Bidders who meet the minimum qualification criteria will be qualified only if their available bid capacity for construction work is equal to or more than advertised value of the work. The available bid capacity will be calculated as under: Assessed Available bid capacity = (A*M*N-B) Were. **A** = Maximum value of civil engineering works executed in any one year during the last five years (updated to the price level of the current financial year at the rate of 7% per year), taking into account the completed as well as works in progress. **N** = 3.0 (Number of years prescribed for completion of the works for which bids are invited) (period up to 6 months to be taken as half-year (0.5) and more than 6 months as one year (1.0)). **B** = Value, at the current price level, of existing commitments and on-going works to be completed concurrently with the works specified upto the period of "N" above as per FIN 4 in section 4.

No:- 749-67
Dated:-11/05/2026
DIP No:DIPK-1212/26

Sd/-
Executive Engineer
I& F C Division Sopore

वरीय पुलिस अधीक्षक का कार्यालय, राँची

सर्वसाधारण के लिए सूचना

नाम–गोखुल राम, उम्र–71 वर्ष, उँचाई–5 फीट 4 ईंच, रंग–गोरा, पहनावा–नीला रंग का हाफ टी शर्ट पहने हुए है।

उपरोक्त लापता व्यक्ति गोखुल राम, उम्र–71 वर्ष, पिता–गरीबा राम, महुगावाँ, थाना–चैनपुर, जिला–पलामु जो दिनांक–23.04.2026 को राँची रेलवे स्टेशन से बगैर बताए कहीं चले गए जो आजतक अपने घर वापस नहीं आए है। जिनकी मानसिक स्थिति ठीक नहीं है। जिसके संबंध में कोंके थाना सन्हा सं0–12/2026, दिनांक–25.04.2026 दर्ज कर इनकी खोजबीन की जा रही है। उपरोक्त सूचना को सार्वजनिक किया जाना आवश्यक है।

अतः सभी जनसाधारण से अनुरोध है कि यदि उपरोक्त लापता व्यक्ति कहीं मिलता / दिखता है तो इसके संबंध में वरीय पुलिस अधीक्षक के कार्यालय में या निम्नांकित फोन नम्बर पर संपर्क कर इसकी सूचना दें।

Email ID(rnc-dcb@jhpolice.gov.in)

पुलिस उपाधीक्षक, मु0 प्रथम, राँची। –9431706141
थाना प्रभारी, कोंके, राँची। –9431706185

वरीय पुलिस अधीक्षक, राँची

PR 379519 (Police)26-27*D

वरीय पुलिस अधीक्षक का कार्यालय, राँची। सर्वसाधारण के लिए सूचना।

नाम–रचना कुमारी उर्फ बानी कुमारी, उम्र–20 वर्ष, उँचाई–05 फिट, रंग–गोरा, पहनावा–गुलाबी रंग का टॉप एवं हरा रंग पलाजो पहनी हुई है।

उपरोक्त लापता महिला रचना कुमारी उर्फ बानी कुमारी, उम्र–20 वर्ष, पिता–राजकुमार बाल्मिकी, सा0–सी0आई0पी0 क्वार्टर 70, थाना–कोंके, जिला–राँची जो दिनांक–16.04.2026 को बगैर बताए कहीं चली गई जो आजतक अपने घर वापस नहीं आई है। जिसके संबंध में कोंके थाना सन्हा सं0–17/2026, दिनांक–17.04.2026 दर्ज कर इनकी खोजबीन की जा रही है। उपरोक्त सूचना को सार्वजनिक किया जाना आवश्यक है।

अतः सभी जनसाधारण से अनुरोध है कि यदि उपरोक्त लापता महिला कहीं मिलती / दिखती है तो इसके संबंध में वरीय पुलिस अधीक्षक के कार्यालय में या निम्नांकित फोन नम्बर पर संपर्क कर इसकी सूचना दें।

Email ID(rnc-dcb@jhpolice.gov.in)

पुलिस उपाधीक्षक, मु0 प्रथम, राँची। –9431706141
थाना प्रभारी, कोंके, राँची। –9431706185

वरीय पुलिस अधीक्षक, राँची।

PR 379517 Police(26-27)D

GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA
Public Works Division, Dharashiv
E-Tender Notice No. :- 01/2026-27

Online Tenders Works are invited by the Executive Engineer, Public Works Division, Dharashiv (Phone No. 02472-222882/83) in B-1 from eligible contractors.

Website :- **http://mahatenders.gov.in & https://pwd.maharashtra.gov.in**

(S. J. Ket)
Executive Engineer
Public Works Division, Dharashiv
Dgipr/2026-27/706

DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS GANDERBAL, J&K.

Beehama Ganderbal 191201, Tel: 0194-2416443
Fax 0194-2416443. Email: dpoganderbal@jkpolice.gov.in

HUE AND CRY NOTICE

SHO Police Station Kheerbawani vide letter No. KBN/-A/2026/1185 dated 09.05.2026 has intimated that on 08.05.2026 one unidentified male dead body was found in the Water Canal gate (Maar Yaab Kul) near Dangerpora Ganderbal. The dead body has been taken in possession and kept in Mortuary at PHC Sonamarg. In this connection Inquest proceeding initiated U/S 194 BNSS..

Description of dead body

Particulars	Not Known
Age	About 28 to 38 years
Height	5' 6"
Complexion	Whitish
Dress	White colored with black striped shoulder T-Shirt & black underwear

You are requested to circulate the same in your respective jurisdictions for Look out, if any information/clue comes to light, kindly inform on below mentioned phone numbers.
1. PCR Ganderbal : 01942416478, 9906668731.
2. SHO P/S Kheerbawani : 7006017372.
3. P/S Kheerbawani : 9541786737.

Sr. Superintendent of Police,
Ganderbal.

DIP/J-1858/26

UJVN Limited

H.O.: "UJJAWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephone: 0135-2763808; Fax: 0135- 2763508
CIN NO. U40101UR2001SGC025866, Website : www.ujvnl.com

RO No. 401 **Short- Term Tender Notice** **Dated : 11/05/2026**

Office of the Executive Engineer (Civil), MB-II, Chinyalisaur (Uttarkashi) invites sealed tender from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:
(1) Tender No: 07/ EE(Civil) / MB-II / Chinyalisaur / 2026-27
(1) Name of work: Repair of Roadside Drains at vulnerable location from Sulidhang to taxi union and Sulidhang to police chowki and near old tehsil building and Enlargement of Culverts at Shaktipuram Colony, MB-II Project, Chinyalisaur, Uttarkashi.
1. Estimated Cost: Rs. 8,42,093.00 (excluding GST)
Date of availability of bid document on website 12.05.2026 from 5:00 PM
Last date for submission of tender 29.05.2026 upto 11:00 AM
For fuller & further detail, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be download from the Nigam's website "www.ujvnl.com"

Executive Engineer (Civil),MB-II,Chinyalisaur

"Avoid wasteful use of Electricity"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./ 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Kapil Singh, S/o: Balram, R/o: Jhuggi No. 218, Outram Lane, GTB Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 001243/21, U/s: 411 IPC, Police Station Mukherjee Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Kapil Singh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Kapil Singh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Kapil Singh** of **Police Station Mukherjee Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **14.07.2026.**

By Order
Ms. Amardeep Kaur
Ld. ACJM, North, Room No. 117,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/6133/NW/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82(2)(ii)Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person namely **Ritik S/o** Malkhan, R/o: Jhuggi No. 1864, G-Block, Jhangirpuri, Dhobi Ghat, Delhi (or is suspected to has committed) the offence in **FIR No. 382/20, Date: 17.08.2020, U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act,** registered at P.S.: Jhangirpuri, Delhi and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused **Ritik** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ritik** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Ritik** accused **FIR No. 382/20, U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act,** registered at P.S.: Jhangirpuri, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **12.06.2026.**

By Order
Ms. Jyoti Nain
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
Court Room No. 05, First Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/6114/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Prakash Verma** S/o Govind Verma R/o S-587 Shakarpur School Block, Shakarpur East Delhi, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 524/2024, CR No. 933/2026 U/s 420/406/120B/34 IPC, PS Krishna Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Prakash Verma** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Prakash Verma** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that **Prakash Verma** in **FIR No. 524/2024, CR No. 933/2026 U/s 420/406/120B/34 IPC, PS Krishna Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **11.06.2026.**

By order
Shri P. Bhargav Rao
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
Room No. 3, Second Floor, East District
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/6196/SHD/2026

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE

ICICI Bank Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Rakesh Kumar-Deceased (Through His Legal Heir)/ Kanta Dayal / LBDEL00002388795	Dda Lig Flat No-56, 4th Floor, Block-B1, Pocket-4, Sector-34, Rohini Delhi 110085 / May 07 2026	January 28, 2026 Rs. 27,94,584.22/-	Delhi/ Ncr

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: May 12, 2026
Place: Delhi/Ncr

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER
P.W.D. BASTAR CIRCLE JAGDALPUR (C.G.)

e-Procurement Tender Notice
https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in

Tender are invited for the Following Works :-
Last Date of Tender Downloading :- 21/05/2026

S. No.	NIT No./ NIT Date	Sytem Tender No. (Tender Call No)	Name of Work	PAC Amount (Rupees in Lacs)
01	02	03	04	05
1	27/2026-27 Date 06/05/2026	190285 (First-Call)	Construction of Vented Causeway with (6 Row 1200 MM, H.P.C. Length 10.00 M.) in Km 4/6 on Dodimarka Junction to Pillur Road Under Sub Division Madded, Distt-Bijapur (C.G.).	32.66
2	28/2026-27 Date 06/05/2026	190286 (First-Call)	Construction of Vented Causeway with (9 Row 1200 MM, H.P.C. Length 15.00 M.) in Km 7/2 on Dodimarka Junction to Pillur Road Under Sub Division Madded, Distt-Bijapur (C.G.).	44.78
3	29/2026-27 Date 06/05/2026	190287 . (First-Call)	Construction of Vented Causeway with (11 Row 1200 MM, H.P.C. Length 20.00 M.) in Km 9/4 on Dodimarka Junction to Pillur Road Under Sub Division Madded, Distt-Bijapur (C.G.).	55.91
4	30/2026-27 Date 06/05/2026	190288 (First-Call)	Construction of Vented Causeway with (11 Row 1200 MM, H.P.C. Length 20.00 M.) in Km 10/6 on Dodimarka Junction to Pillur Road Under Sub Division Madded, Distt-Bijapur (C.G.).	55.91
5	31/2026-27 Date 06/05/2026	190289 (First-Call)	Construction of Vented Causeway with (14 Row 1200 MM, H.P.C. Length 25.00 M.) in Km 11/8 on Dodimarka Junction to Pillur Road Under Sub Division Madded, Distt-Bijapur (C.G.).	66.30
6	32/2026-27 Date 06/05/2026	190290 (First-Call)	Construction of Vented Causeway with (17 + 17 Row 1200 MM, H.P.C. Length 60.00 M.) in Km 5/8 on Dodimarka Junction to Pillur Road Under Sub Division Madded, Distt-Bijapur (C.G.).	159.52
7	33/2026-27 Date 06/05/2026	190291 (First-Call)	Construction of Vented Causeway (Rapta Culvert) at Chilkapalli to Polampalli Road Blcok- Usoor, Distt-Bijapur (C.G.). (PART-1 + PART-2)	131.82

For more details on the Tender and bidding process please visit the above mentioned portal.

Superintending Engineer
P.W.D. Bastar Circle
Jagdalpur

G 262700631/ 7

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE

ICICI Bank Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	M/s. Pixie Dreams Private Limited/ Vijay Chauhan/ Vijay Prakash/ Surya Prakash Yadav/ Ajay Chauhan/ 157805006837	Property Bearing Flat No.202 on The 2nd Floor, Admeasuring Area 737.00 Sq. Feet i.e. 68.47 Sq. Mtrs Carpet Area, Building No.13 in Avenue- M, Known As "Rustomjee Evershine Global City Avenue- M, Building No.17, Co-Operative Housing Society Ltd., in The Complex Known As "Rustomjee Evershine Global City", Land Bearing Survey No.5, 5B, 5F & 5G, Lying, Being & Situate At Village Dongare (Old Village Naringi), Taluka Vasai, District- Palghat, Within The Area of Sub-Registrar At Vasai No. 1 to 6, Maharashtra- 401303., Owned By Vijay Prakash, Admeasuring An Area of 737.00 Sq. Feet i.e. 68.47 Sq. Mtrs Carpet Area. North: As Per Sale Deed South: As Per Sale Deed East: As Per Sale Deed West: As Per Sale Deed./ Symbolic Date 07 May 2026	December 18, 2025 Rs. 99,99,431.81/-	Noida

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: May 12, 2026
Place: Noida

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

CLIX HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED

Registered Office: W2/14, 1st Floor, West Patel Nagar, Delhi, 110008

"APPENDIX-IV-A" [See proviso to rule 8(6)] Sale notice for sale of Immovable Properties

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described Immovable property mortgaged/ charged to the **Clix Housing Finance Limited** (CLIX) (Secured Creditors), the constructive possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of **Clix Housing Finance Limited** (CLIX), Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" basis on **17.04.2026**, for recovery of amount as mentioned below, due to the Secured Creditors from following Borrower(s), Guarantor(s) and Corporate Guarantor(s). The reserve price and earnest money to be deposited is mentioned below respectively

Name of Borrower, Co-Borrower/ Guarantor(s) with address/es	Description & Owner(s) of Properties
1. Jay Prakash S/O Prem Shankar, 2. Matee Sumita Devi W/O Prem Shankar, 3. Prem Shankar S/O Sukhpal, All At - H. No. G-404, Gali No. 20, West Karawal Nagar, New Delhi-110090, **Also At:-** Plot No. A-2/3, Ugf (Front Rhs), Dlf Ankur Vihar Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-20120, **Sr No. 1 Also At:-** Sai Collection, A-415, 1 Gali No. 2, Sanjay Colony, Okhla Phase-2, New Delhi-110020. **Loan A/c No. (AC2019031359215) (Along with future Interest and charges accruing after 28.03.2025 till the total realization of the loan amount)**	All That Piece And Parcel Of Flat No. U.G.F. -1, Mig, Upper Ground Floor Front Side (Rhs) (Without Roof Right) At Plot No. A-2/3, Admeasuring 46.44 Sq. Meters I.E. 50 Sq. Ft. Dlf Ankur Vihar Ghaziabad, U.P. Bounded By: East:- Other's Flat West:- Road 12 Meter Wide North: Flat No. A-2/4 South: Other's Flat

Reserve Price (RP) & EMD & Incremental Amount	Recovery Amount as per Demand Notice	Date & Time of On-Site Inspection of Property	Date & Time of E-Auction with unlimited extensions of 5 Minutes each
Rs. 22,52,250/- & Rs. 2,25,225/- & Rs. 50,000/-	Rs.18,44,472.73/- as on 28.03.2025	15.06.2026 to 16.06.2026 From 10.00 AM to 5.00 PM	17.06.2026 11 Am to 1 Pm (with unlimited extensions of 5 Minutes each)

EMD amount shall be remitted through NEFT/RTGS/Funds Transfer in favour of "Clix Housing Finance Limited", Account No. 341905000653_ICICIBANK_IFSC-ICIC0003419

Last date for deposit of EMD and uploading Bid documents: 16-06-2026 Till 12.00 PM at www.bankeauctions.in

The balance 25% of final purchase price minus EMD Amount shall be deposited by the successful bidder, latest by the next working day by way of RTGS / NEFT in the E-Auction account of Clix. The balance 75% of the final purchase shall be deposited by way of RTGS / NEFT within 30 days from the date of auction in the same E-Auction account as above. The refund of EMD to the unsuccessful bidders shall be made only in the account number mentioned by such bidder in the Bid form within 5 working days. **Terms and Conditions :- E-auction is being held on "AS IS WHERE IS" and "AS IS WHAT IS" and "WHATEVER THERE IS" basis** and will be conducted "Online". The auction will be conducted through Clix's approved service provider C1 India Pvt. Ltd. at the web portal www.bankeauctions.in. Bid Documents, Declaration, General Terms and Conditions of online auction sale are available in www.bankeauctions.in. To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer, there is no encumbrance on the properties. However, the intending bidders should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of properties put on auction and claims/rights / dues/ affecting the property/ies, prior to submitting their bid, in this regard, the a-Auction advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of Clix. For any details with respect to any help, procedure and onl1ne training in respect of the auction process please contact **Mr. Ayush Gupta, (M) 9999916811, E mail ID. delhi@c1india.com.** for any details regarding the property please contact +91-7291981124 / 25 / 26. It may please be noted that in case of any discrepancy/ inconsistency between auctions notices published in English and in Hindi then the contents of the notice published in English shall prevail. The Authorised Officer/ Secured Creditor shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims/ rights/ dues. The sale shall be subject to rules/ conditions prescribed under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security interest Act, 2002 **STATUTORY 30 DAYS SALE NOTICE UNDER THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002.**

Place : Ghaziabad, Date: 12.05.2026 **Authorized Officer, CLIX HOUSING FINANCE LIMITED**

UJVN LIMITED

H.O.: "UJJAWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephones: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvnl.com

Letter No: 395 **Tender Notice** Dated: 11/05/2026

Office of the Executive Engineer (E&M), MB-II,Joshiyara Barrage, Joshiyara Uttarkashi invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:
Tender No. 01/EE(E&M)/MB-II/Barrage/2026-27&02/EE(E&M)/MB-II/Barrage/2026-27.
Name of work/supply/services: 1- Repair and Maintenance of PLC and SCADA system at Joshiyara Barrage, MB-II, Uttarkashi
2- Repairing and Servicing of 100 KVA and 400 KVA DG Sets at Joshiyara Barrage, MB-II, Uttarkashi.
Estimated cost: Rs. 8,04,800.00 Only (GST Extra) & Rs. 3,82,195.00 Only (GST Extra)
Date of availability of bid document on website: 12.05.2026
Last date for submission of tender: 03.06.2026, 16:00 hrs
For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. Ther tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website **"www.ujvnl.com"**

Executive Engineer(E&M)

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

IT WAS A BIG LULL: KIARA ADVANI

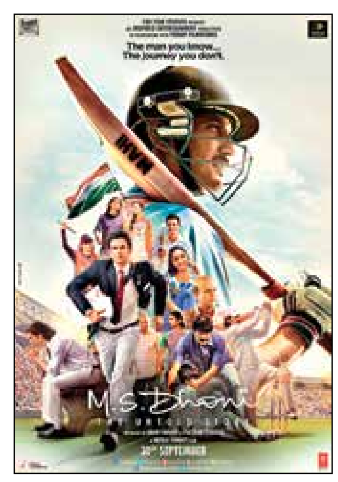
She said the success of 'MS Dhoni: The Untold Story' biopic didn't end her struggle in Bollywood

Kiara Advani recently reflected on her early struggles in the film industry, particularly the challenging phase following her debut film, 'Fugly'. She also opened up about how she landed the opportunity to star in 'Lust Stories' on 'Netflix'.

During a candid podcast with Raj Shamani, Kiara shared that every low phase in her career has served as a learning experience for her. "I really feel like there is something that I've learnt from every single experience and it has shaped me today. It's the lows that have been my biggest teachers. To date, people think that 'MS Dhoni' or 'Kabir Singh' was my first film, because those were commercial hits. 'Fugly' was my first film; not many people saw it. Many people might Google it now," the actor said.

> Kiara shared that every low phase in her career has served as a learning experience for her

She further added, "After that 'Fugly', there was a big lull because the film didn't open well. However, critically, several critics praised my performance. But nothing translated into work. So, it was the same waiting game as going to auditions, some making it, some not. Lots of your choices are also limited. When you are starting off and don't deliver commercially, the opportunities coming your way are much less. The process is longer. To date, I feel that was the best thing that happened to me."



Even after finding success with 'MS Dhoni: The Untold Story', Kiara admitted that the struggle continued. "Even after 'Dhoni', it was the same story. 'Kabir Singh' was released in 2019 and then there was no looking back. Those five years had a lot of auditions, waiting, rejections and a few films that I was shooting for. I knew work would bring work and that actually happened," she said. AGENCIES

Babil set to feature in 'GANDHI BAZAR'

Khan will make his Malayalam debut with the film

NEW DELHI: Bollywood actor Babil Khan is set to make his Malayalam debut with 'Gandhi Bazar'. The film is directed by Babu Janardhanan and will also feature Aparna Balamurali, Deepak Parambol, Nikhil Nair, Johny Antony, Jagadish, Sudheer Karamana, Unni Raja, Athmiya and Jayashankar in pivotal roles.

A source close to the actor said Khan has always opted for the stories that challenge him. "Babil has always been drawn to stories that challenge him and allow him to grow as an artist. Stepping into Malayalam cinema with a project of this scale and creative depth is an incredibly exciting moment. It reflects his desire to explore powerful narratives beyond boundaries and collaborate with storytellers who inspire him," the source added.

> A source close to the actor said Khan has always opted for the stories that challenge him

Khan, the son of late actor Irrfan Khan, made his acting debut in 2022 with the 'Netflix' psychological drama film 'Qala'. He is known for his role in 'The Railway Men' series, which revolved around the horrific 1984 Bhopal Gas Tragedy.

Babil's last work is the 2025 cyber-thriller film 'Logout', which premiered on 'ZEE5'. It was directed by Amit Golani and also starred Nimisha Nair alongside Khan. PTI

'Once you become famous, you become relevant'

He has long been a subject of fascination as the guy who hangs out with star children and Bollywood celebrities. Orhan Awatramani, better known to the world as Orry, said that as he rose to prominence, he was often told that his '15 minutes of fame' would end soon.

> Orry said that as he rose to prominence, he was often told that his '15 minutes of fame' would end soon

With 2.4 million followers on 'Instagram', trending reels, an appearance on 'Koffee With Karan' and cameos in shows and movies such as 'Call Me Bae' and 'Nadaaniyaan', Orry said he has proved the naysayers wrong.

"I was initially privately famous and then I chose to become publicly famous. Initially, everyone was like, 'His 15 minutes will end'. It's been three years and my 15 minutes are still going. Your watch is broken," the influencer told PTI.

Orry added, "Once you become famous, you become relevant. So, I was pushing and the day I got famous, you have to keep the fame up." AGENCIES

'The Devil Wears Prada 2' delivers a stylish 'reality check'

The iconic fashion drama returns with a darker, sharper take on layoffs, digital media and survival in the age of metrics

ANINDITA ACHARYA

Irv Ravitz (Tibor Feldman), the CEO of 'Elias-Clarke', which publishes 'Runway', dies of a heart attack on the evening he was about to make Miranda Priestly (Meryl Streep) the head of content of the magazine group. His son Jay Ravitz (BJ Novak) takes his place, but he believes in downsizing, cost-cutting and clickbait content. He is in a rush and brings in management consultants to recommend cost cuts. Miranda bears it all without any complaints.

As I sit there in a multiplex in central Kolkata for an afternoon show with a meagre crowd (mostly girls and Gen Z), I find myself having a déjà vu. I also felt a pang in my chest. I have seen it all before - the same exercise of downsizing, mergers, cost-cutting and eventually shutdowns. In 2017, when I was working with a premier media organisation (I was part of their newspaper vertical), I saw how, within months, the house crumbled. Journalists were terminated, multiple editions and bureaus closed, after a major consulting firm visited the company to restructure it and accommodate a massive digitisation programme.

When 'The Devil Wears Prada' was released in 2006, I was in college. Truth be told, I didn't watch it then. It was only after I joined the features department of a reputed media organisation that I watched it. At that time, the world of high fashion, stilettos and expensive brands, glass offices and the zeal to prove oneself, just like Andrea (Anne Hathaway), excited me. Maybe many like me, back then, wanted to be Andrea. Streep's Miranda became a pop culture phenomenon. Her 'That's all', her icy-cold responses and impossible standards became reference points for nervous but ambitious journalists trying to survive intimidating newsrooms.

Emily Blunt gets the best lines this time. "May the bridges I burn light my way," or the way she says, "Shared carbs have no calories." Her expressions are spot on

But that was 20 years ago. Today, print revenues are dipping, the digital ecosystem is steering media organisations toward clickbait news and algorithms and metrics have changed editorial jobs at publishing houses. Now, you are mostly judged by how many articles you have filed and how many clicks and reactions they got, rather than the impact and value of the article itself. Serious journalism no longer pays well. Clickbait does.

And this is where the sequel does better. This one is about much more than luxurious lifestyles and wardrobe choices. This one is about layoffs, downsizing and cost-cutting, the buzzwords of today's job market, especially in the age of Artificial Intelligence. Even Miranda's imperious and icy-cold nature (she still remains so) has taken a hit. Gone are the days of her throwing coats and bags on assistants' desks. No one runs for her coffee anymore and she is constantly reminded to keep a check on her bluntness by her first assistant, Simone Ashley (Amari). And unlike Andrea or Andy Sachs, Amari isn't terrified of Miranda.

When the first-look posters and shooting videos were doing the rounds on the internet last year, as a fan of the earlier film, I honestly didn't want Miranda to return and risk spoiling the legacy of the original. But this sequel feels necessary. It is a reality check for media organisations that carry a legacy but have shifted to digital. The film shines a spotlight on how employees are sacked over a phone call or an email (like what recently happened at an IT company) and how the legacy of an organisation is now measured by metrics and algorithms.

But despite all the seriousness, 'The Devil Wears Prada 2' doesn't lose its satire, biting humour and wit and special thanks for that goes to Emily (Miranda's former first assistant and now a retail head at 'Dior'). The race to the top is gruesome but also entertaining and no one does it better than Emily. Of course, we miss Miranda's iconic "Why is no one ready?" and "That's all", but sorry, this time it is Emily who gets the best lines. "May the bridges I burn light my way," or the way she says, "Shared carbs have no calories." Her expressions are spot on.

Hathaway's Andy is no different, except this time she returns to her former organisation to 'restore the credibility' of 'Runway'. And just like in the previous film, she once again tries to save Miranda and her editorial reign. Stanley Tucci also returns as Miranda's faithful stylist Nigel, toiling away patiently while still keeping his eye on Andy.

And if you think amid all this there isn't fashion, well, there is. The climax unfolds in Milan and you see high fashion everywhere. And then there's Streep, proving at the age of 76 why she remains the queen of expressions. Miranda knows the media world has changed, but she also knows her standards and ways haven't. I missed her iconic hair flip and grand entry sequence, but the Dries Van Noten tassel jacket and that subtle shake when she enters the lift for an impromptu meeting with consultants over cost-cutting make up for everything else. It's iconic. There's simply no one who can do what Streep does. Every single time.

So, gird your loins, because this sequel serves high fashion with an equally high reality check. That's all.

Film: The Devil Wears Prada 2
Director: David Frankel
Cast: Meryl Streep, Anne Hathaway, Emily Blunt, Stanley Tucci